Sicilian Defence.

Every line, step by step · Mishika's take-home from Coach Akshat

> All lines and both games from Alessia Santeramo's video *"Learn the Sicilian Defense in 40 minutes"* (YouTube, nhmYYQpY7tM). The moves were read off the video's board; the explanations, ideas and tricks are ours, checked with Stockfish 19. Boards are drawn from Black's side, the way Mishika sees them.

How to read the boards

White's move · Black's move · Black's plan (idea boards) · White's idea or threat

Each board shows one move pair: White's move and Black's answer, with an arrow for each and one line on why it was played. At the end of every line, **Pip's idea** shows who is better, why, and what to play next. If Stockfish found a checkmate trick near the end of a line, it is shown move by move in a ♛ **Checkmate trick** box.

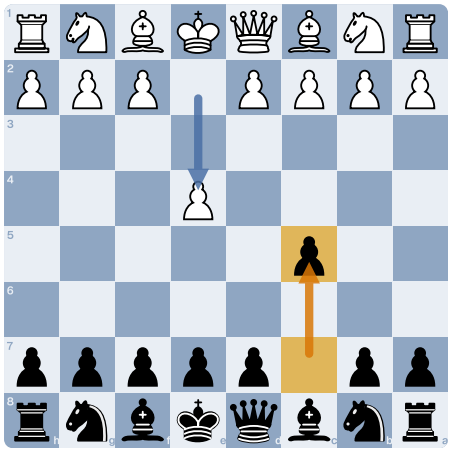
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2. **Bishop to c4**: White checks on b5
3. **Open Sicilian**: Why we take on d4, Punish 5.e5, The knights trade, The ...e5 fork, The g5 trick, Fast plan: ...d5!, Slow build-up, Punish 10.e5
4. **Closed Sicilian**: White takes on d5, White pushes e5, White plays f4
5. **Alapin 2.c3**: Don't play 2...e6, The answer: 2...d5!, Another way: 2...Nf6
6. **The video's two games**: Game 1: trap the bishop, Game 2: the hidden check

First moves

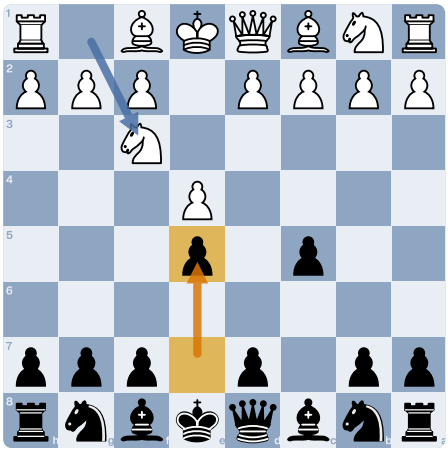
1.e4 c5 is the Sicilian. Here is one move Black should never play, and two early queen attacks that don't work.

Don't play 2...e5



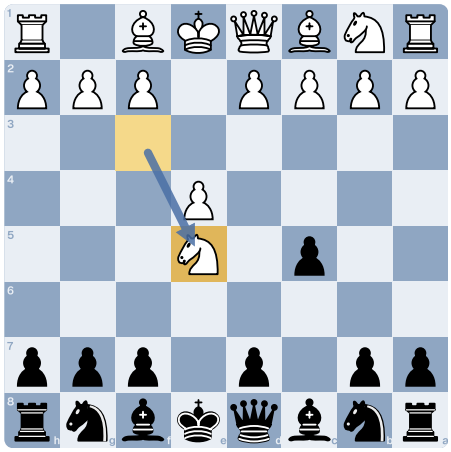
1.e4 White takes the centre.

1...c5 The Sicilian: the c-pawn guards d4 from the side, so White can't have two centre pawns.

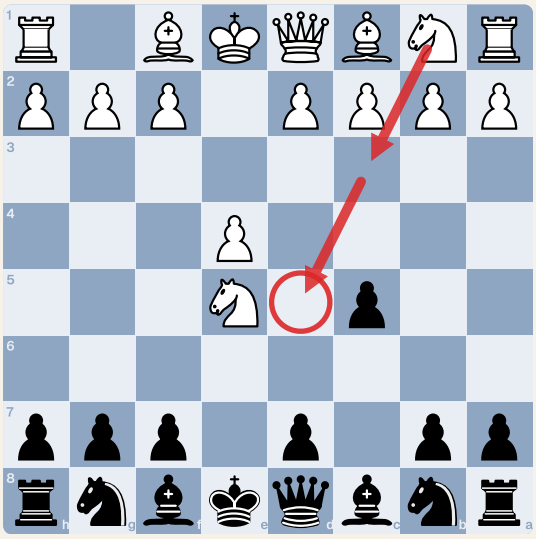


2.Nf3 Develop and get ready for d4.

2...e5? Leaves a hole on d5 and the pawn isn't safe.



3.Nxe5 White just takes it.



PIP'S IDEA: WHERE THIS LINE ENDS

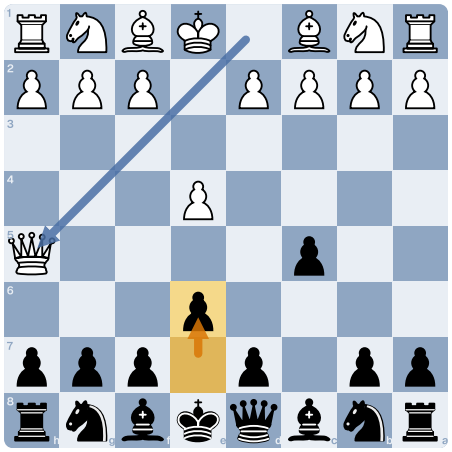
White is a pawn up

White's idea

- White's knight took e5 for free and now sits in the middle of the board.
- d5 is a hole: no black pawn can ever guard it, so White's pieces will land there.
- That's why we play 2...e6: it keeps d5 covered.

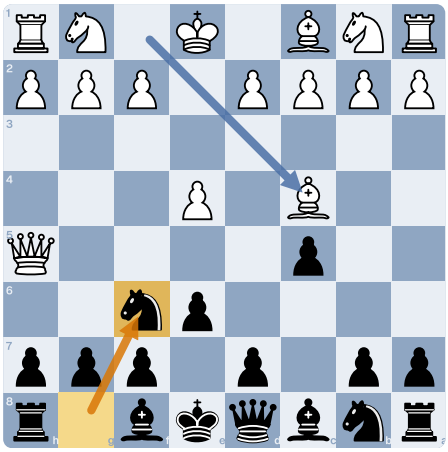
Early queen: 2.Qh5

Start from: 1.e4 c5



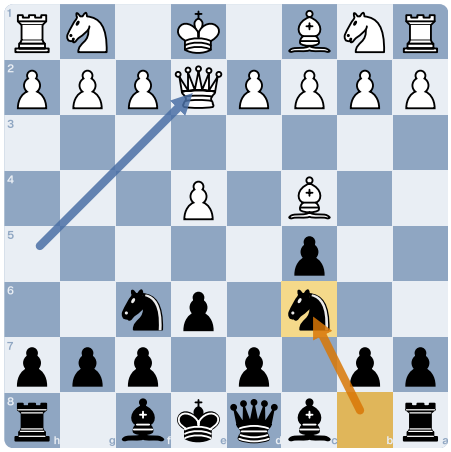
2.Qh5 An early queen, hoping for a quick mate.

2...e6 Guards f7's diagonal and opens the f8 bishop.



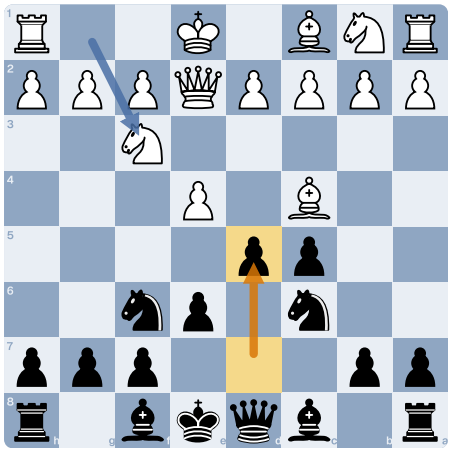
3.Bc4 The bishop only hits the e6 wall.

3...Nf6 Hit the queen and the e4 pawn.



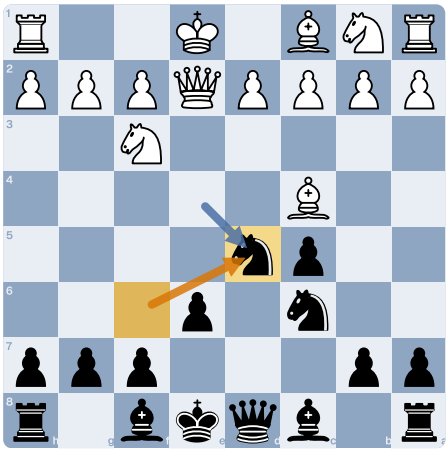
4.Qe2 The queen runs and guards e4.

4...Nc6 Develop.



5.Nf3 White develops.

5...d5! Take the centre.



6.exd5 White takes.

6...Nxd5 The e6 pawn is pinned, so the knight takes back.



PIP'S IDEA: WHERE THIS LINE ENDS

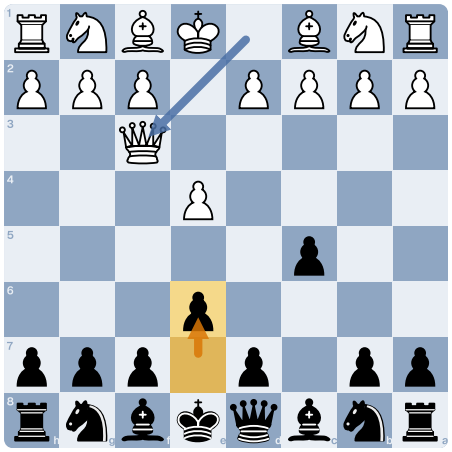
Black is comfortable

Black's plan Key square

- White's queen has moved twice and still attacks nothing.
- Black's knight sits on d5, a great square in the centre.
- Next: ...Be7 to free the pinned e6 pawn, then castle.

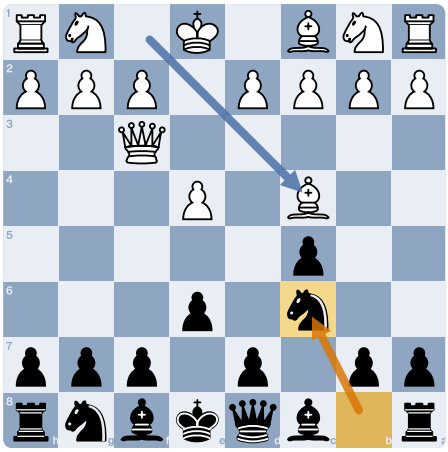
Early queen: 2.Qf3

Start from: 1.e4 c5



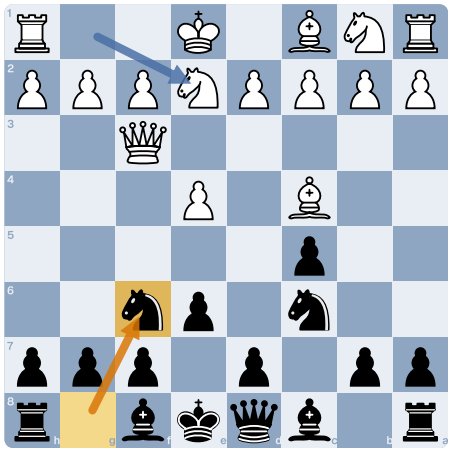
2.Qf3 The queen takes the knight's best square.

2...e6 Same habit: ...e6.



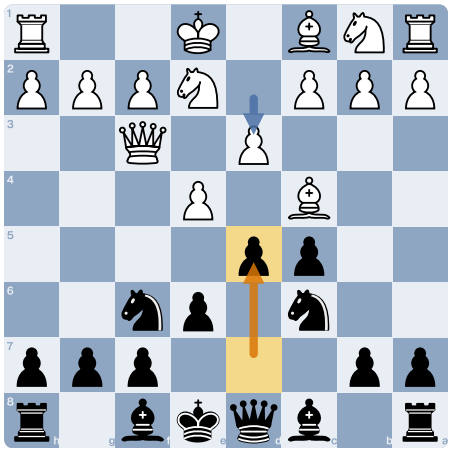
3.Bc4 The bishop hits the e6 wall.

3...Nc6 Develop and watch d4.



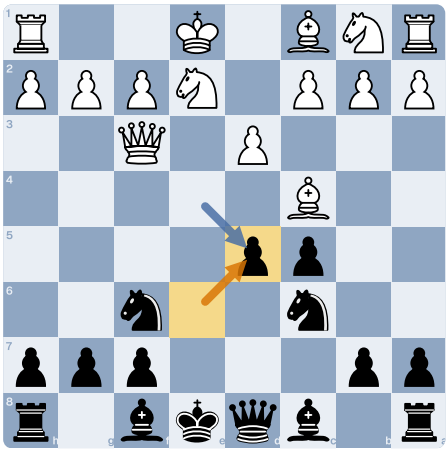
4.Ne2 The knight can't use f3, because the queen is there.

4...Nf6 Both knights out.



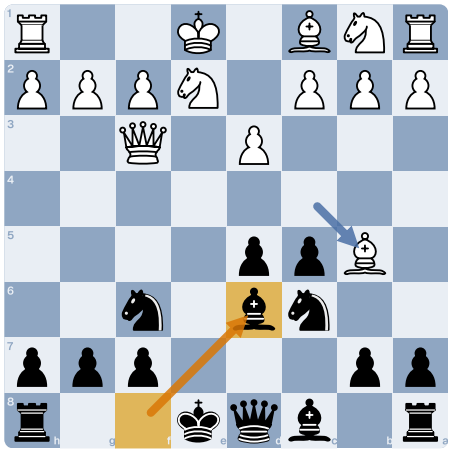
5.d3 Guards e4 and frees the c1 bishop.

5...d5! Hit the centre.



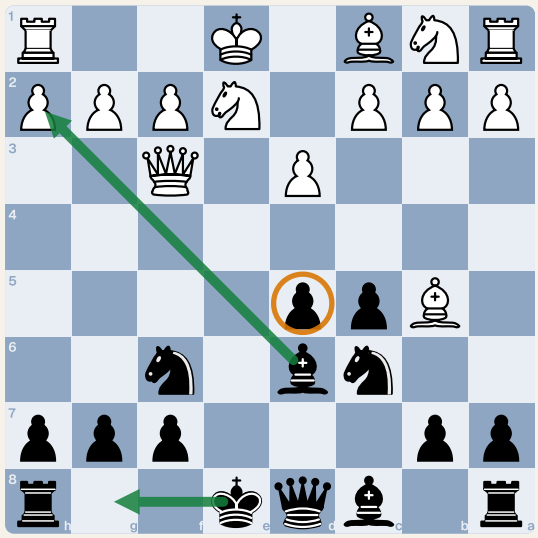
6.exd5 White takes.

6...exd5 Take back with the pawn: the centre is Black's.



7.Bb5 Pin the c6 knight.

7...Bd6 Develop and get ready to castle. Black is better.



PIP'S IDEA: WHERE THIS LINE ENDS

Black is better

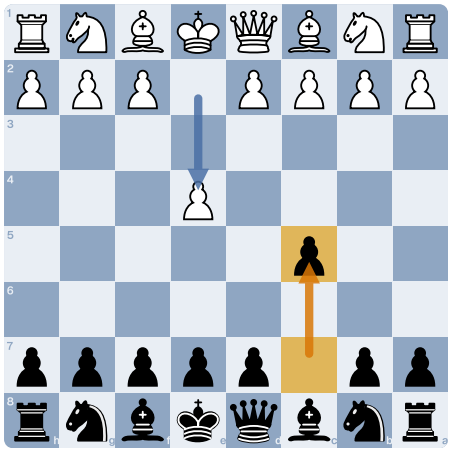
Black's plan Key square

- Black has the only centre pawn (d5) and is ready to castle.
- The queen on f3 takes the knight's best square, so White's pieces are clumsy.
- Next: castle, then ...Re8 on the open e-file. The d6 bishop already aims at h2.

Bishop to c4

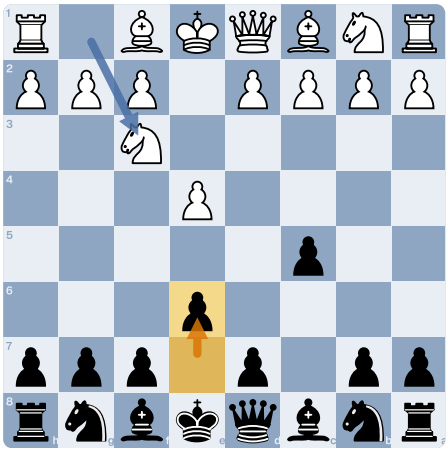
White puts the bishop on c4, like in the Italian. It hits a wall on e6, so Black plays ...d5! at once.

White checks on b5



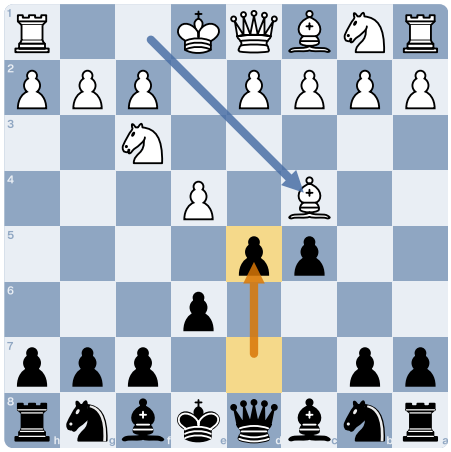
1.e4 White takes the centre.

1...c5 The Sicilian: the c-pawn guards d4 from the side, so White can't have two centre pawns.



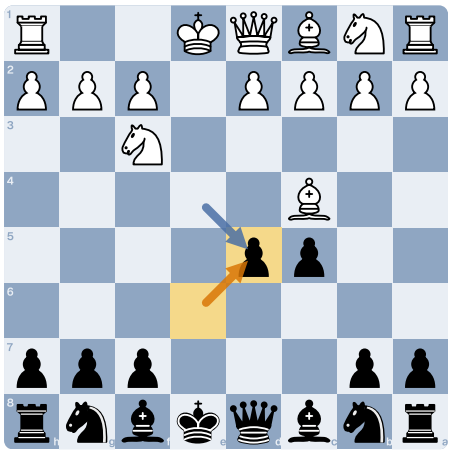
2.Nf3 Develop and get ready for d4.

2...e6 Our setup. The e6 pawn guards d5 and opens a road for the f8 bishop.



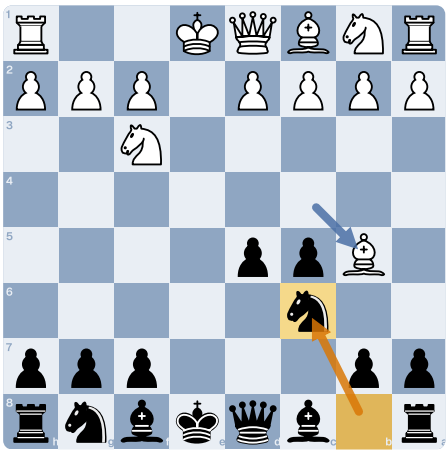
3.Bc4?! Copies the Italian, but the bishop runs into the e6 pawn.

3...d5! Hit the bishop and the centre at once.



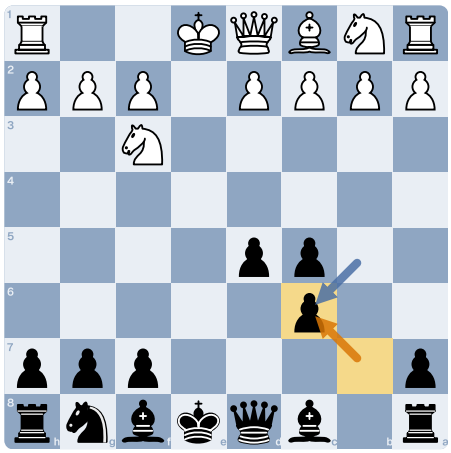
4.exd5 White takes, so the bishop doesn't have to move.

4...exd5 Black now has the only centre pawn, and the c8 bishop is free.



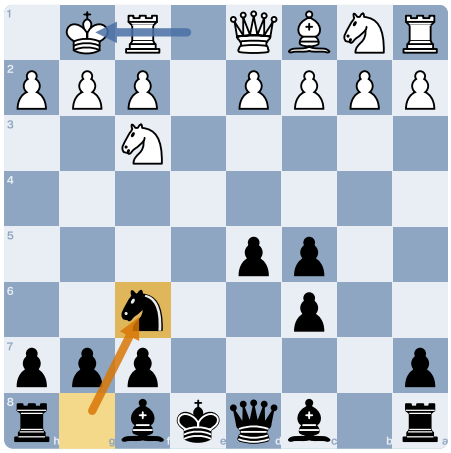
5.Bb5+ The most common square: a check.

5...Nc6 Block with a new piece.



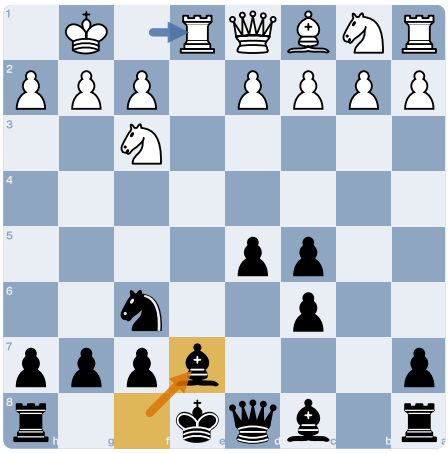
6.Bxc6+ White trades the bishop for the knight to give Black doubled pawns.

6...bxc6 Doubled pawns, but the c6 pawn guards d5, and Black keeps both bishops.



7.O-O White castles.

7...Nf6 Develop the last knight.



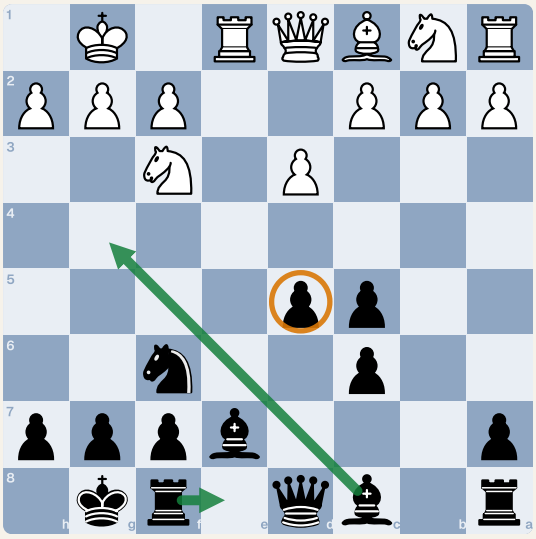
8.Re1+ The e-file is open: this is why we hurry to castle.

8...Be7 Block with the bishop, and now Black can castle.



9.d3 White opens a road for the c1 bishop.

9...O-O Castled. Black is fine.



PIP'S IDEA: WHERE THIS LINE ENDS

Even game, and Black is happy

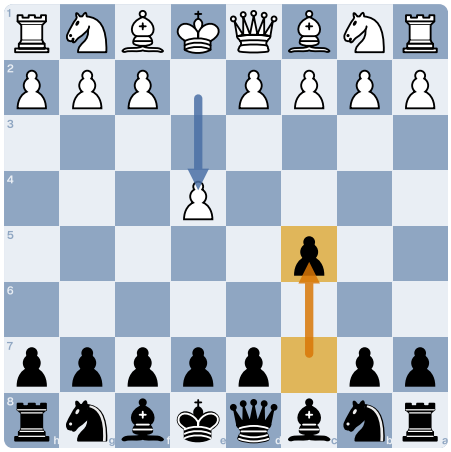
Black's plan Key square

- Black is castled and has both bishops. The c8 bishop has an open road.
- The c6 pawn guards d5, so the doubled pawns are not a weakness here.
- Next: …Re8 on the open file, and …Bf5 or …Bg4.

Open Sicilian

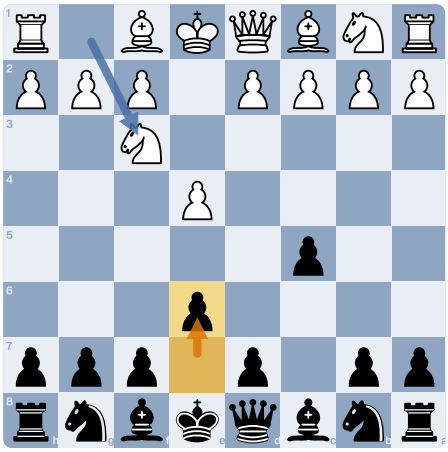
3.d4 opens the centre. Take on d4, develop the knights, and watch for White's tricks.

Why we take on d4



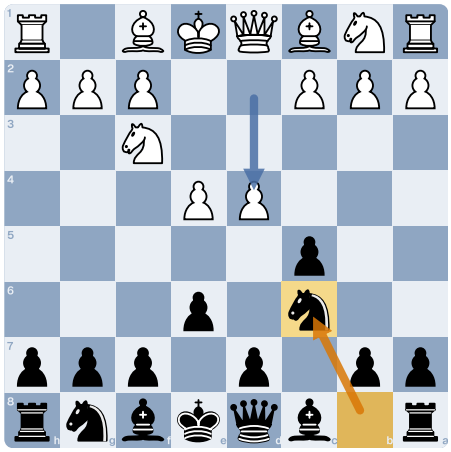
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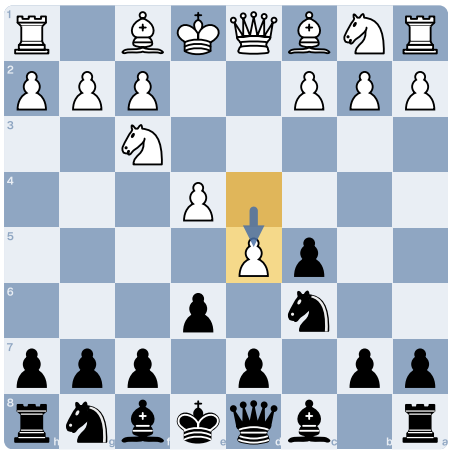
2.Nf3 Develop and get ready for d4.

2...e6 Our setup. The e6 pawn guards d5 and opens a road for the f8 bishop.

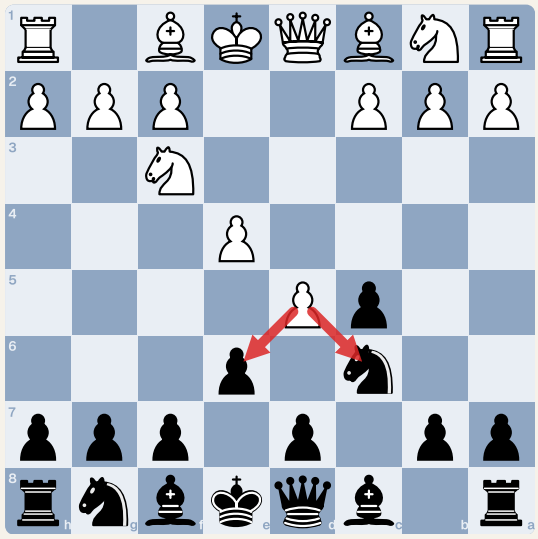


3.d4 The Open Sicilian: White opens the centre.

3...Nc6? Doesn't trade.



4.d5! The pawn pushes on and kicks the knight. White gets lots of space.



PIP'S IDEA: WHERE THIS LINE ENDS

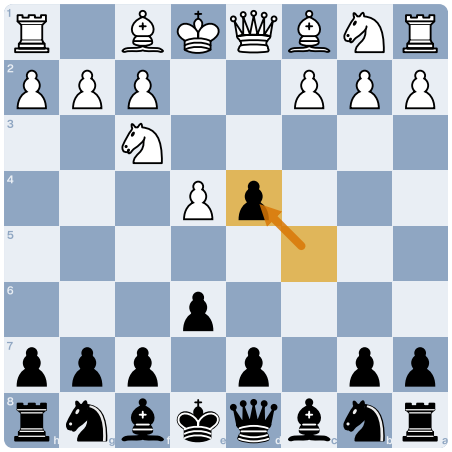
White is much better

White's idea

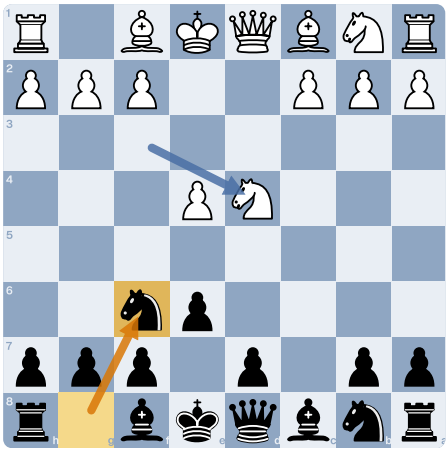
- The d5 pawn kicks the c6 knight before it has done anything.
- White has lots of space, and Black's pieces have fewer good squares.
- Lesson: after 3.d4, always take with 3...cxd4.

Punish 5.e5

Start from: 1.e4 c5 2.Nf3 e6 3.d4



3...cxd4! Trade a side pawn for a centre pawn.



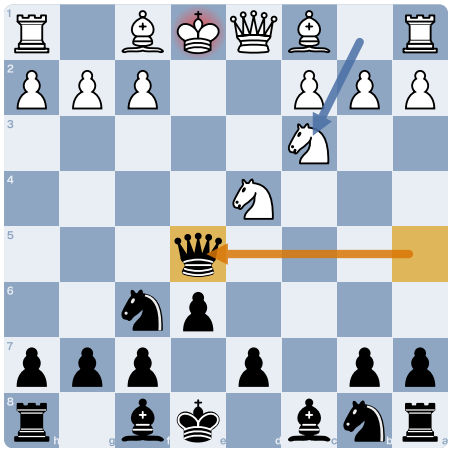
4.Nxd4 The knight takes back and sits in the centre.

4...Nf6 Develop and hit e4.



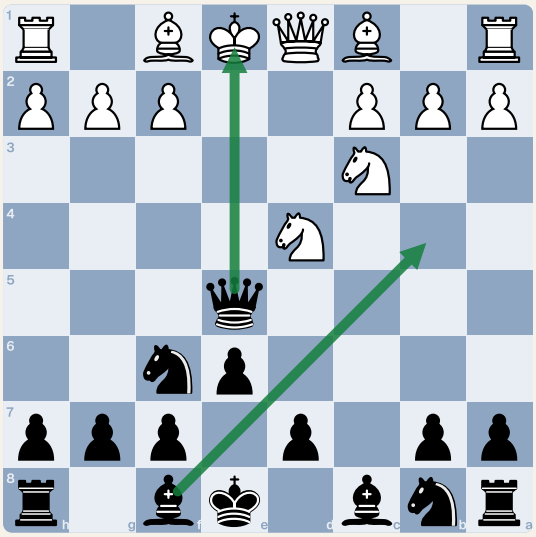
5.e5? Kicks the knight, but...

5...Qa5+! ...check, and the queen also hits e5.



6.Nc3 Block the check with a knight.

6...Qxe5+ Black wins a centre pawn.



PIP'S IDEA: WHERE THIS LINE ENDS

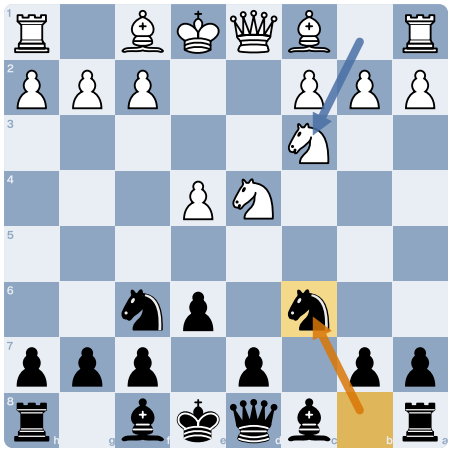
Black is a pawn up

Black's plan

- Black won White's e-pawn, and it is check.
- Black has two centre pawns (d7 and e6); White has none.
- Next: develop fast with ...a6, ...Qc7 and ...Be7 (or ...Bb4), then castle.

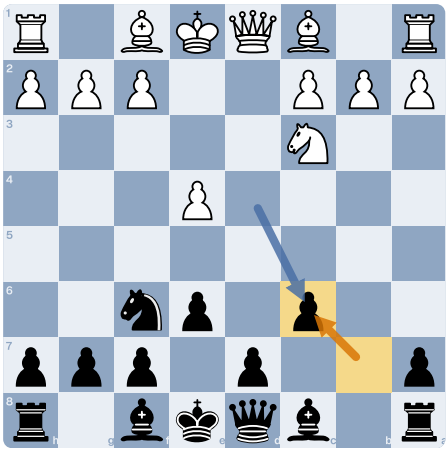
The knights trade

Start from: 1.e4 c5 2.Nf3 e6 3.d4 cxd4 4.Nxd4 Nf6



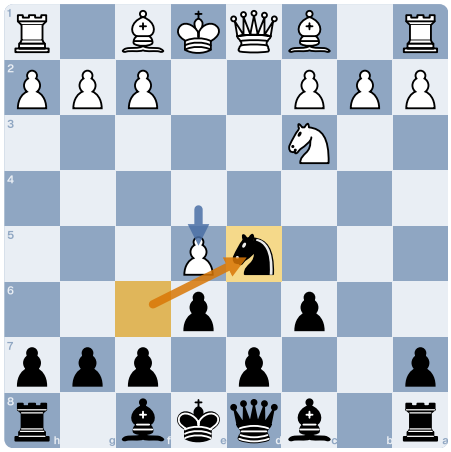
5.Nc3 Guards e4 with a piece. Now ... Qa5 isn't a check any more.

5...Nc6 Develop. (5...d6 is fine too.)



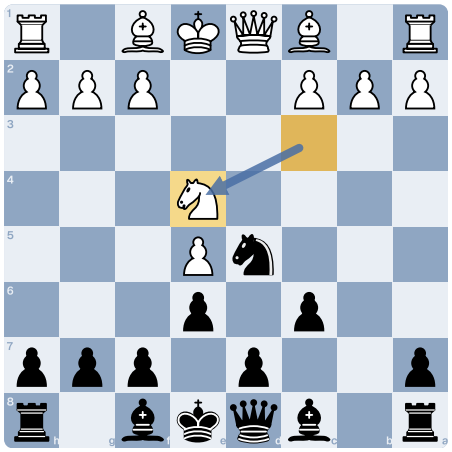
6.Nxc6 White trades knights.

6...bxc6! Take towards the centre.

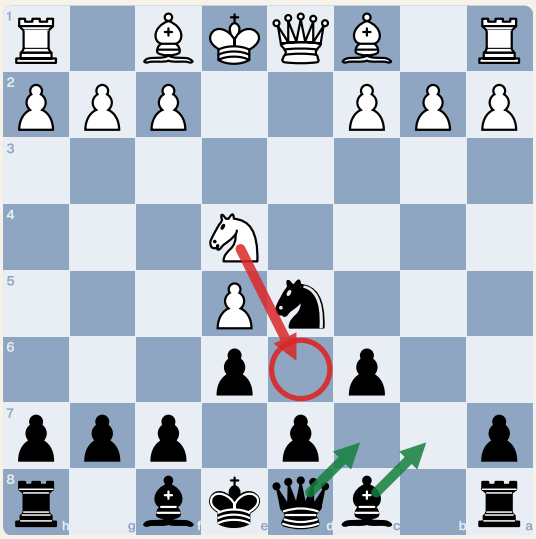


7.e5 Kick the f6 knight.

7...Nd5 The knight gets a great central square.



8.Ne4 The white knight also heads for the centre.



PIP'S IDEA: WHERE THIS LINE ENDS

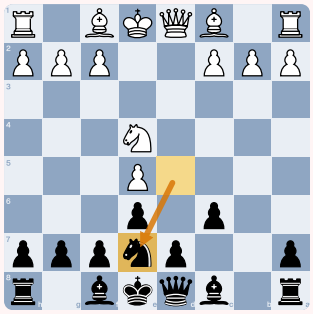
Even game

Black's plan — White's idea

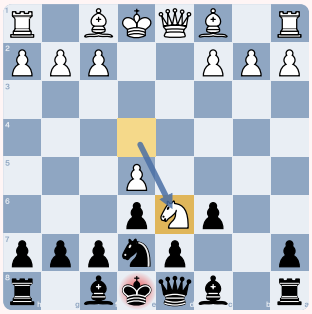
- Black's knight on d5 is a strong central piece.
- White's e5 pawn takes space, but it can become a target.
- Watch the d6 square: Nd6+ is White's trick. Next: ...Bb7 and ...c5, or ...Qc7 to hit e5.

♚ Checkmate trick: never put the knight on e7 here

Black's king has the d7 pawn, the d8 queen and the f8 bishop around it, so e7 is its only free square. If the d5 knight drops back to e7, White's knight jumps to d6 and it is checkmate.



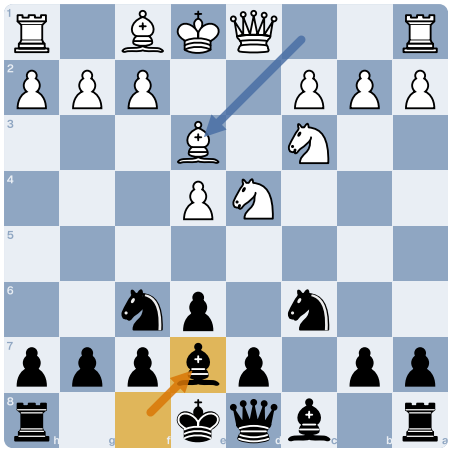
8...Ne7 Looks like a calm retreat, but it takes the king's last square.



9.Nd6# Checkmate! The e5 pawn guards the knight, and the king has nowhere to go.

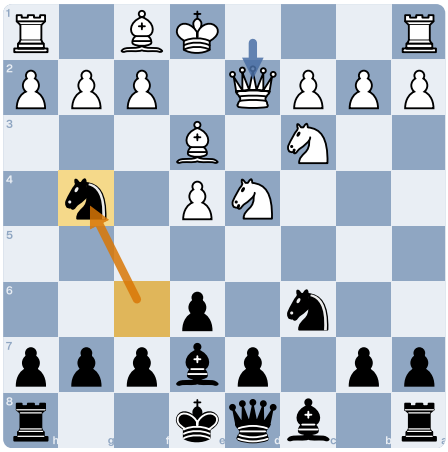
The ...e5 fork

Start from: 1.e4 c5 2.Nf3 e6 3.d4 cxd4 4.Nxd4 Nf6 5.Nc3 Nc6



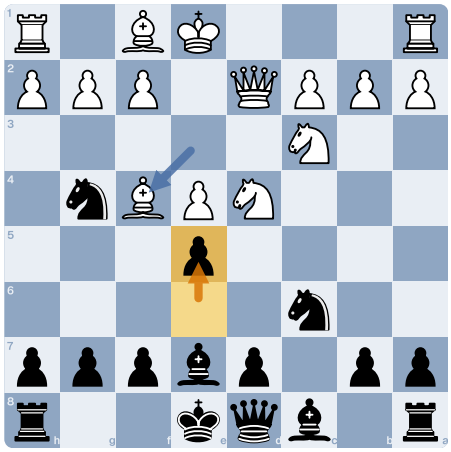
6.Be3 The most flexible move: it guards d4 again.

6...Be7 Get ready to castle.



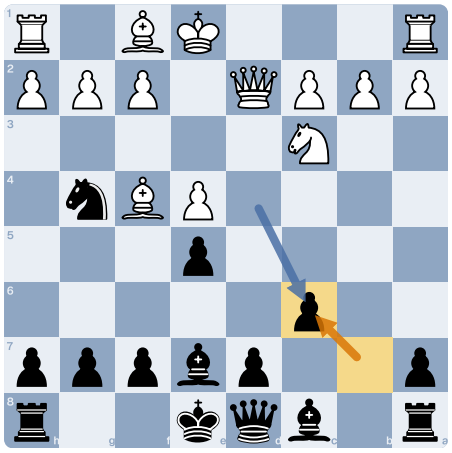
7.Qd2?! Too early.

7...Ng4! Go after the e3 bishop.



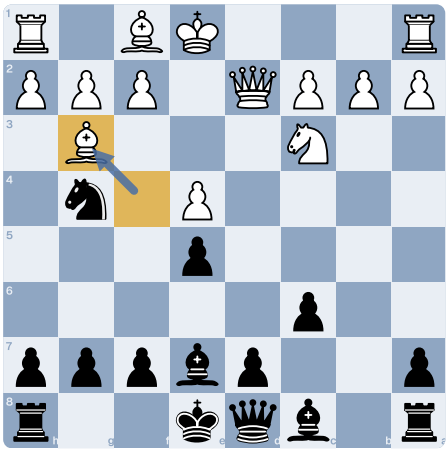
8.Bf4 The bishop runs, but stays on an open diagonal.

8...e5! Pawn fork: bishop and knight.

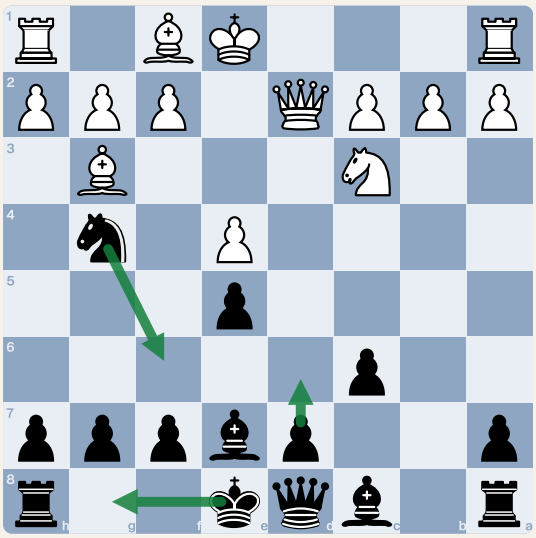


9.Nxc6 White takes first, so only one piece is left hanging.

9...bxc6 Take back towards the centre.



10.Bg3 The bishop escapes, and Black is comfortable.



PIP'S IDEA: WHERE THIS LINE ENDS

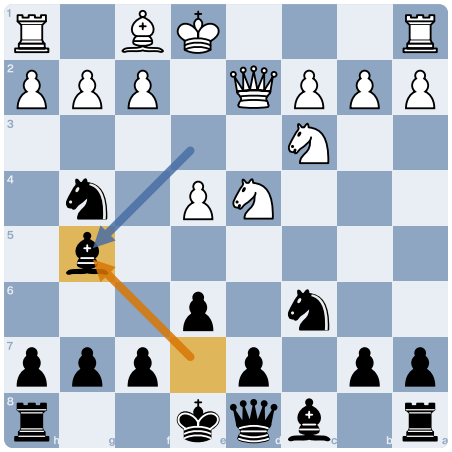
Even game

Black's plan

- The fork didn't win a piece, but the e3 bishop had to leave. That was the point of ...Ng4.
- Black has a strong pawn on e5 and an active knight on g4.
- Next: ...d6, ...Nf6 and castle.

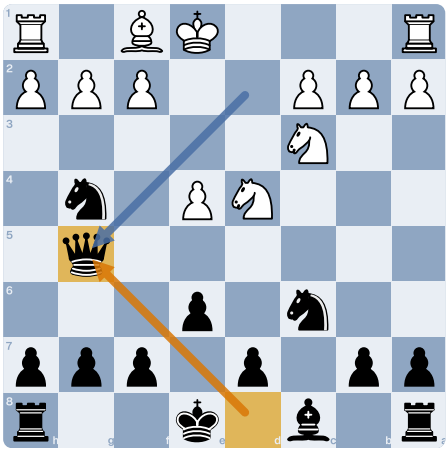
The g5 trick

Start from: 1.e4 c5 2.Nf3 e6 3.d4 cxd4 4.Nxd4 Nf6 5.Nc3 Nc6 6.Be3 Be7 7.Qd2 Ng4



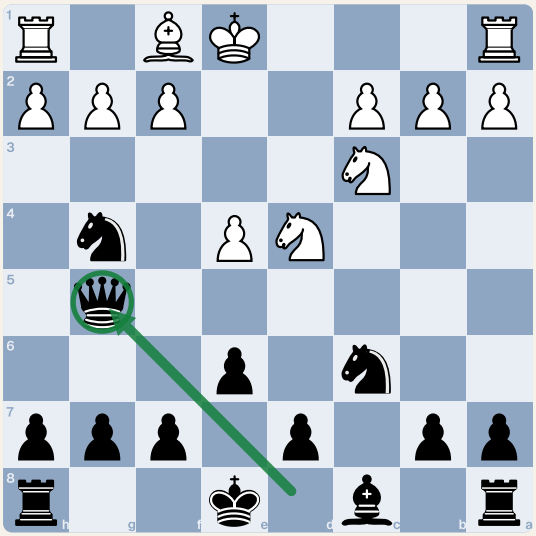
8.Bg5? The bishop runs to g5, but it isn't safe there.

8...Bxg5 Take it.



9.Qxg5?? Takes back, but...

9...Qxg5 ...the d8 queen sees g5. White loses the queen.



PIP'S IDEA: WHERE THIS LINE ENDS

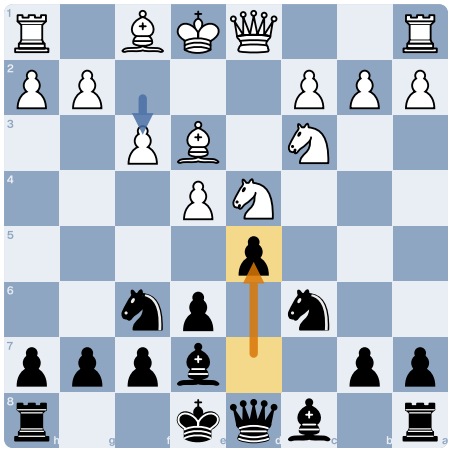
Black wins: a whole queen up

Black's plan

- Black is a whole queen up.
- The trick: once the e7 bishop moved, the d8 queen could see all the way to g5.
- Before you take back, look at what is behind the piece you take.

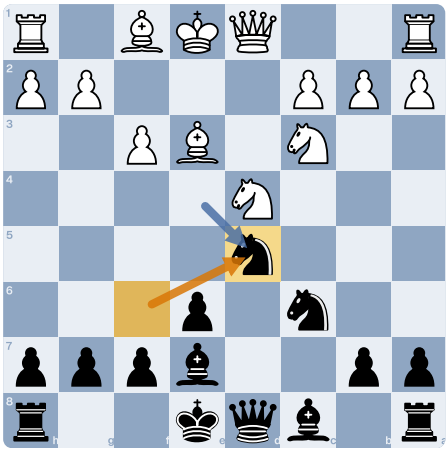
Fast plan: ...d5!

Start from: 1.e4 c5 2.Nf3 e6 3.d4 cxd4 4.Nxd4 Nf6 5.Nc3 Nc6 6.Be3 Be7



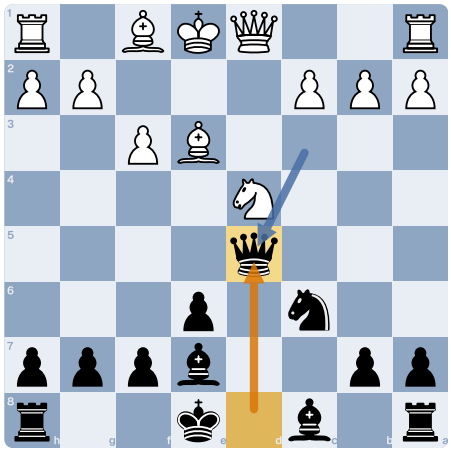
7.f3 Guards e4 and stops ...Ng4. White wants Qd2 and castling long.

7...d5! The fast plan: hit the centre right away.



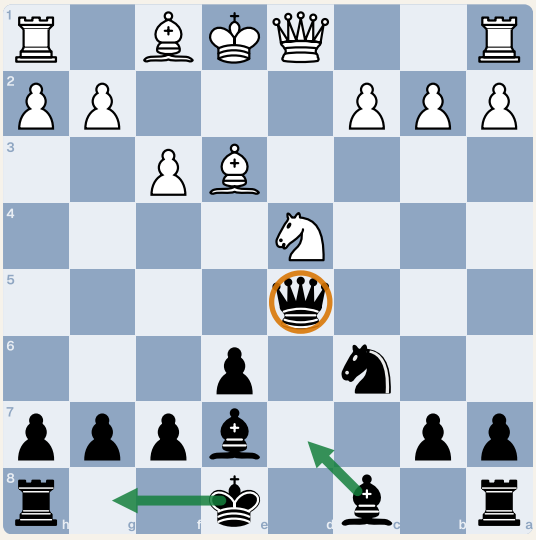
8.exd5 White takes.

8...Nxd5 The knight takes back and sits in the centre.



9.Nxd5 White trades knights.

9...Qxd5! Take with the queen: no lonely pawn, and no knight can chase her.



PIP'S IDEA: WHERE THIS LINE ENDS

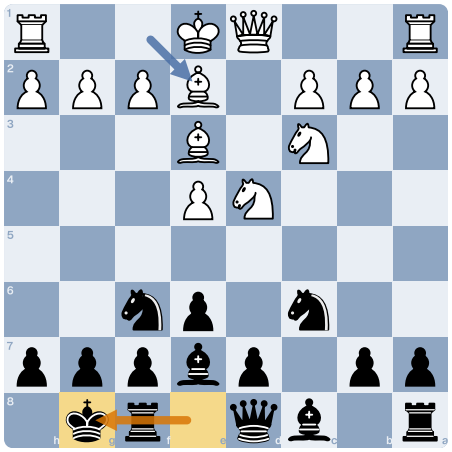
Even game: the fast plan worked

Black's plan Key square

- Black has no weak pawns, and no knight or bishop can chase the queen from d5.
- White wants to castle long; Black's queen and rooks will aim down the c- and d-files.
- Next: castle short and develop the c8 bishop with ...Bd7.

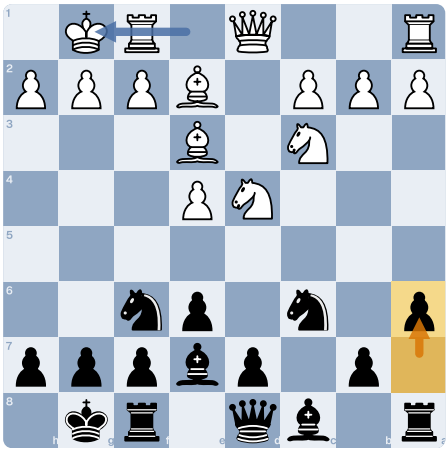
Slow build-up

Start from: 1.e4 c5 2.Nf3 e6 3.d4 cxd4 4.Nxd4 Nf6 5.Nc3 Nc6 6.Be3 Be7



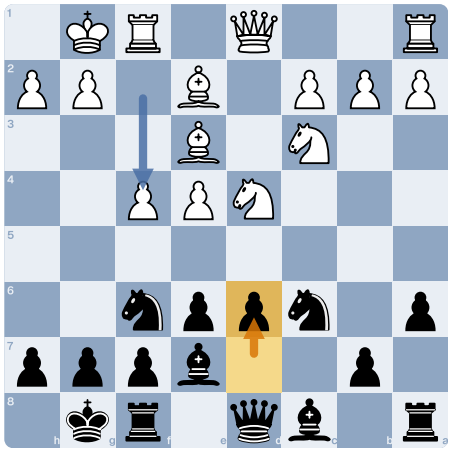
7.Be2 The quiet way: White castles short.

7...O-O Castle.



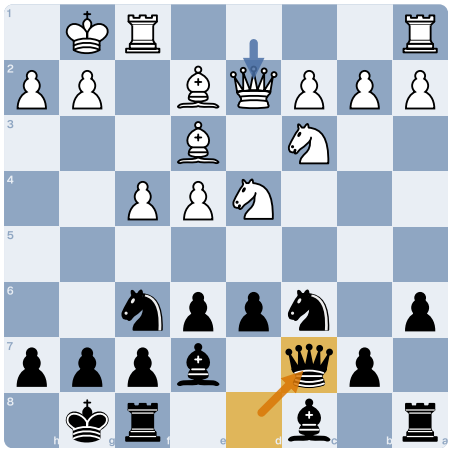
8.O-O White castles too.

8...a6 Keeps knights off b5 and gets ready for ...Qc7 and ...b5.



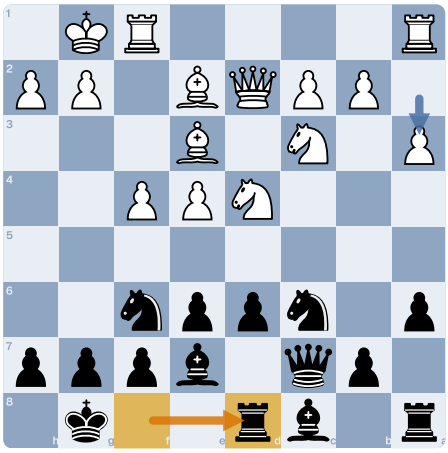
9.f4 White's idea is e5.

9...d6! Stop e5.



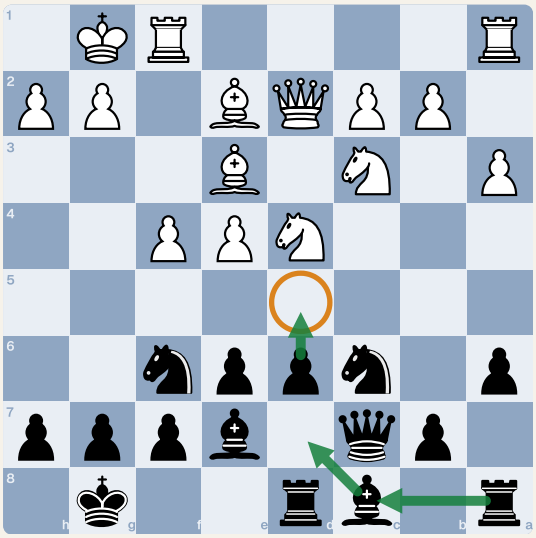
10.Qd2 White joins up the rooks.

10...Qc7 On c7 the queen is safe from the knights.



11.a3 A waiting move that keeps ...b4 away later.

11...Rd8 Rook to the d-file, ready for ...d5.



PIP'S IDEA: WHERE THIS LINE ENDS

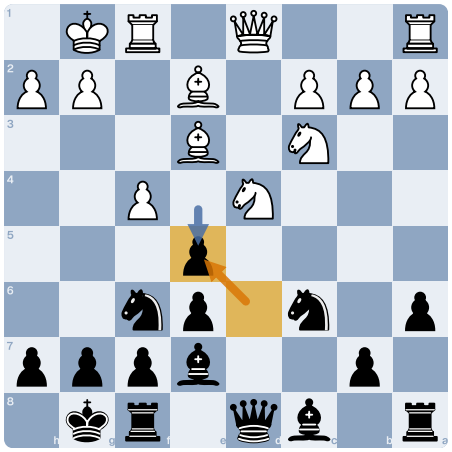
Even game: the set-up is ready

Black's plan Key square

- Every black piece is out, the king is safe, and no knight can chase the c7 queen.
- The d8 rook backs up d6 and gets ready for ...d5.
- Next: ...Bd7 and ...Rac8, or ...Nxd4 and ...e5. Play ...d5 only when every recapture on d5 works.

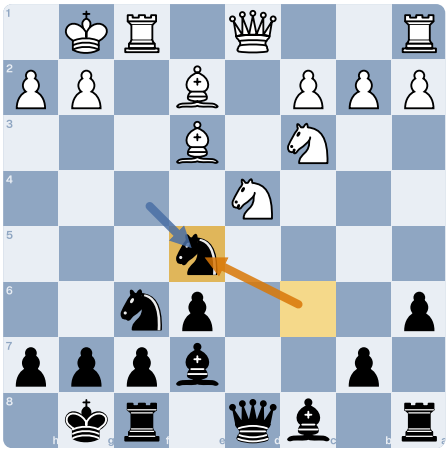
Punish 10.e5

Start from: 1.e4 c5 2.Nf3 e6 3.d4 cxd4 4.Nxd4 Nf6 5.Nc3 Nc6 6.Be3 Be7 7.Be2 O-O 8.O-O a6 9.f4 d6



10.e5? Pushes too early.

10...dxe5 Take.



11.fxe5 White takes back, but nothing guards the new e5 pawn.

11...Nxe5 Black wins a pawn.



PIP'S IDEA: WHERE THIS LINE ENDS

Black is a pawn up

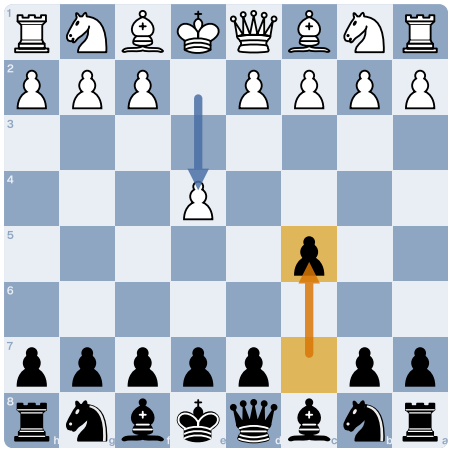
Black's plan Key square

- White's e-pawn is gone, and the knight on e5 is a strong central piece.
- The d-file is open: Black's queen looks straight at the d4 knight.
- Next: ...Bd7 and ...Qc7, then the rooks to the c- and d-files.

Closed Sicilian

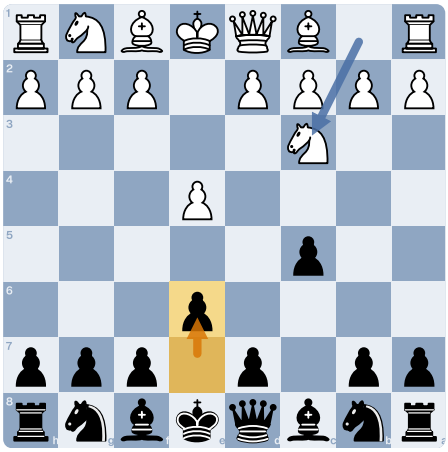
2.Nc3 keeps things closed. Play ...e6 and ...d5, then develop everything.

White takes on d5



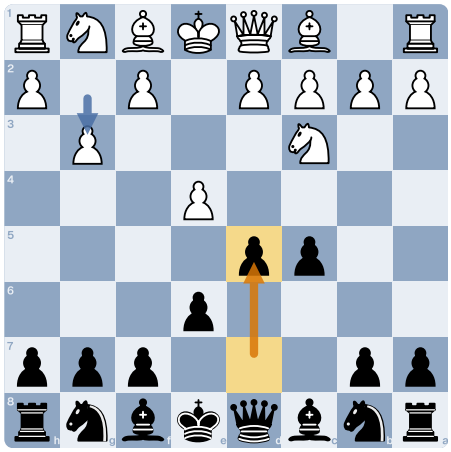
1.e4 White takes the centre.

1...c5 The Sicilian: the c-pawn guards d4 from the side, so White can't have two centre pawns.



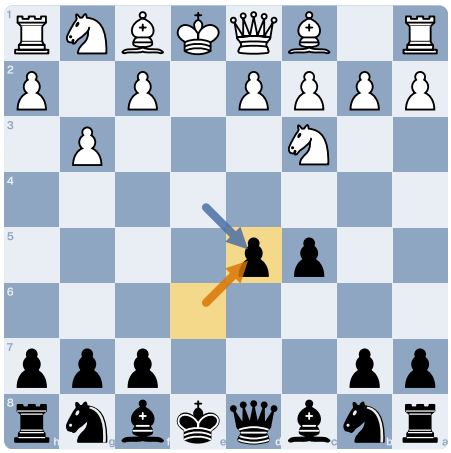
2.Nc3 The Closed Sicilian: White keeps the centre closed.

2...e6 Same setup as always.



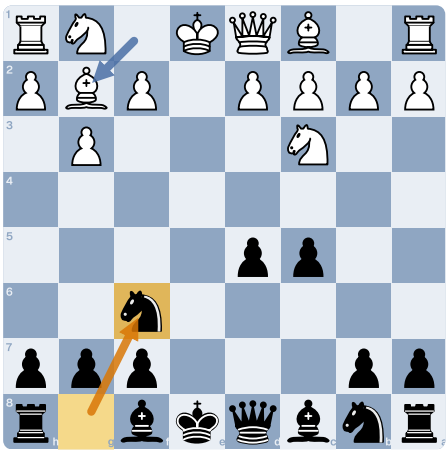
3.g3 The bishop will go to g2.

3...d5! Against quiet moves, hit the centre with ...d5.



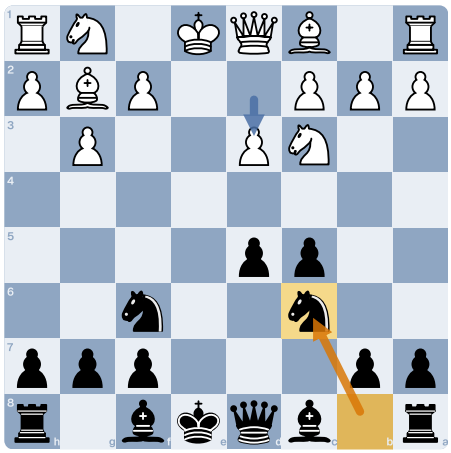
4.exd5 White takes.

4...exd5 Take back with the pawn and keep a centre pawn.



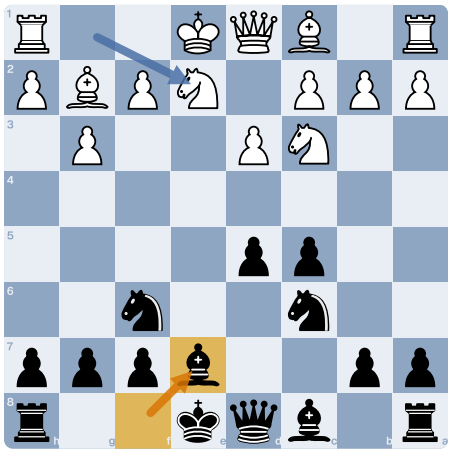
5.Bg2 Now d5 is attacked twice.

5...Nf6 Guard it a second time.



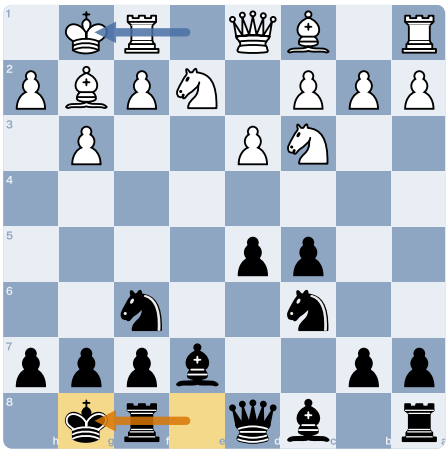
6.d3 White frees the c1 bishop.

6...Nc6 Develop, and watch d4.



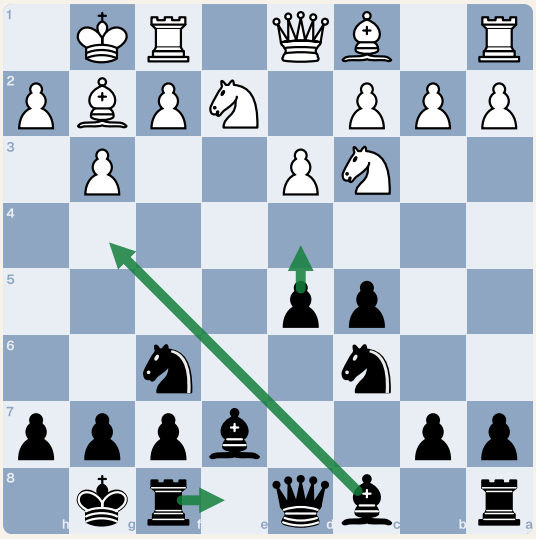
7.Nge2 White develops the other knight.

7...Be7 Ready to castle.



8.O-O White castles.

8...O-O Everything out. Equal.



PIP'S IDEA: WHERE THIS LINE ENDS

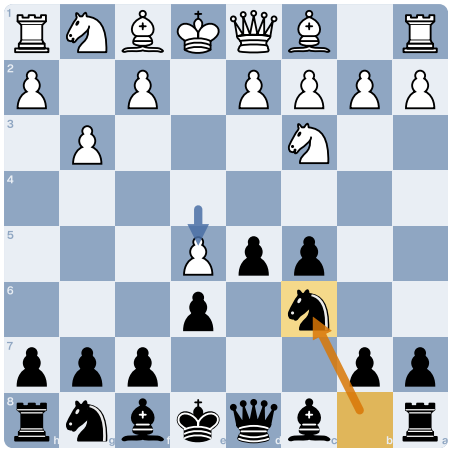
Even game

Black's plan

- Both kings are safe, and d5 has two defenders (the f6 knight and the queen).
- Black has more space in the centre with pawns on c5 and d5.
- Next: …d4 to push the c3 knight away, then …Re8 and …Bg4 or …Be6.

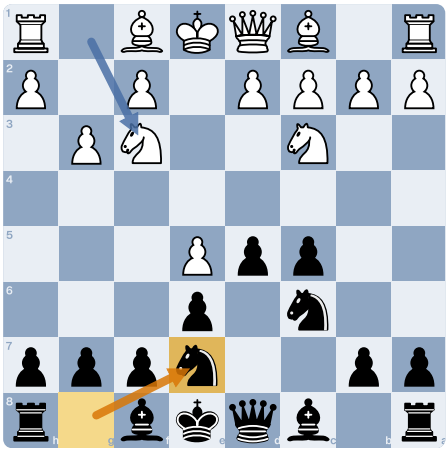
White pushes e5

Start from: 1.e4 c5 2.Nc3 e6 3.g3 d5



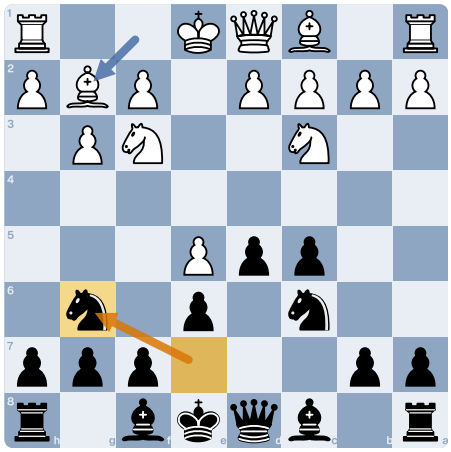
4.e5 Pushes past and grabs space.

4...Nc6 Hit e5 at once.



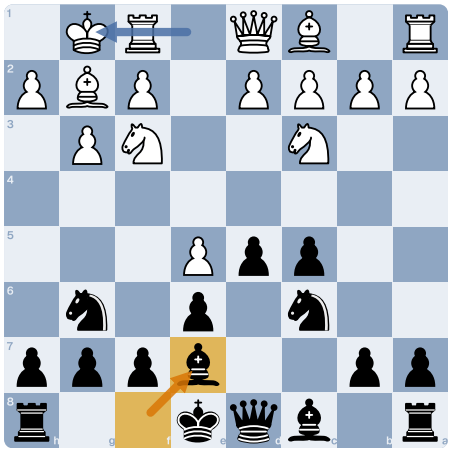
5.Nf3 White guards e5.

5...Nge7 The e7 square is free for the knight first.



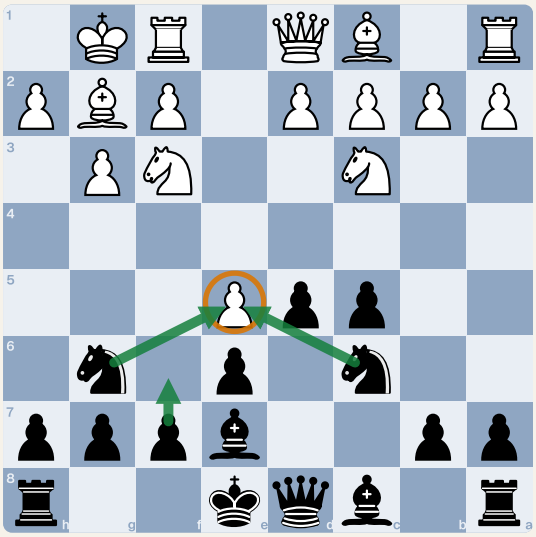
6.Bg2 Bishop to the long diagonal.

6...Ng6 Hit e5 again.



7.O-O White castles.

7...Be7 Castle next, then keep hitting e5.



PIP'S IDEA: WHERE THIS LINE ENDS

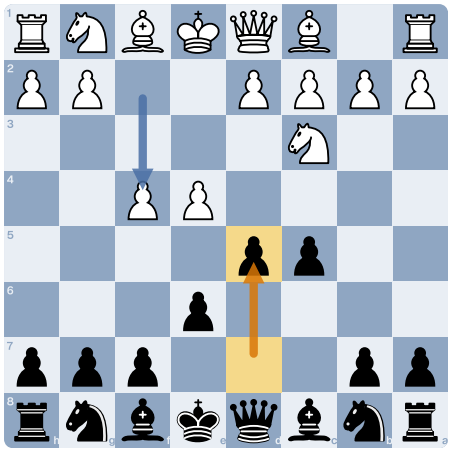
Black is a little better

Black's plan Key square

- The e5 pawn is hit by the c6 and g6 knights and guarded only by the f3 knight.
- Black's c5 and d5 pawns take lots of room in the centre.
- Next: castle, then break with ...f6 (or ...Qc7) to win or swap off e5.

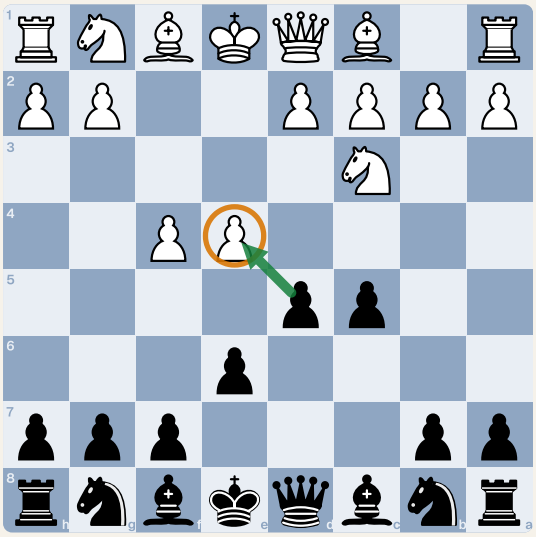
White plays f4

Start from: 1.e4 c5 2.Nc3 e6



3.f4 The f-pawn joins in.

3...d5! The same answer: hit the centre.



PIP'S IDEA: WHERE THIS LINE ENDS

Even game

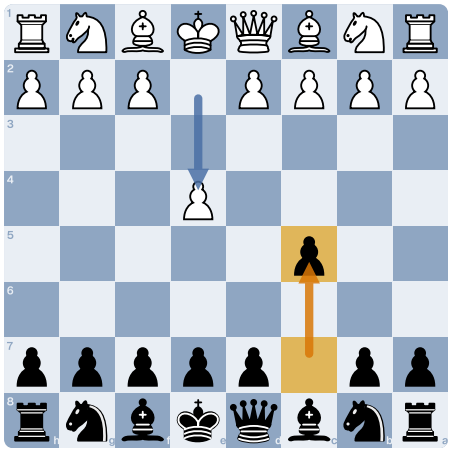
Black's plan Key square

- Black hits e4 straight away, so White has to decide now.
- If White takes on d5, Black takes back with the pawn and the e-file opens: castle quickly.
- If White pushes e5, use the plan from the e5 line: ...Nc6, ...Nge7 and ...Nf5.

Alapin 2.c3

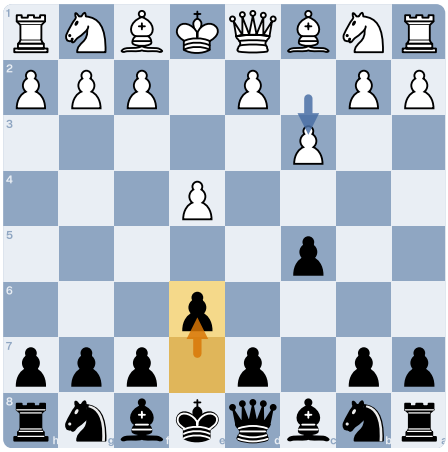
2.c3 wants d4 with a pawn behind it. Hit the centre at once with ...d5!

Don't play 2...e6



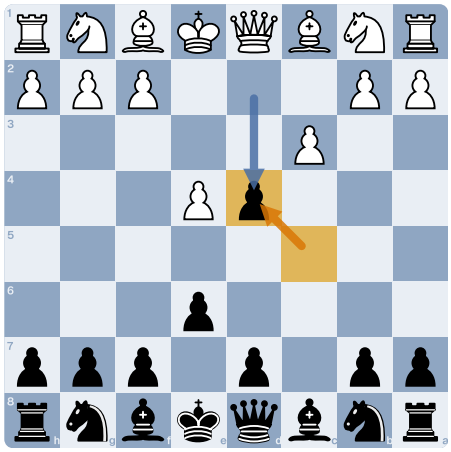
1.e4 White takes the centre.

1...c5 The Sicilian: the c-pawn guards d4 from the side, so White can't have two centre pawns.



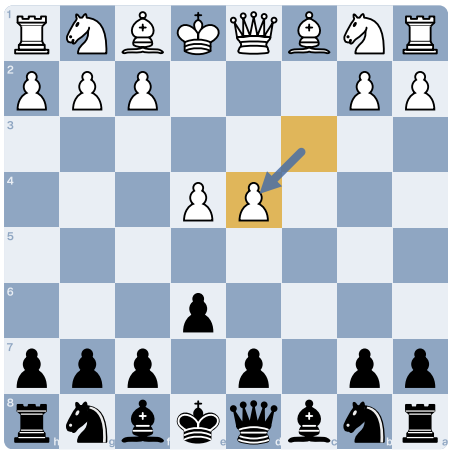
2.c3 The Alapin: White wants d4 and to take back with a pawn.

2...e6?! Our usual move is a mistake here.

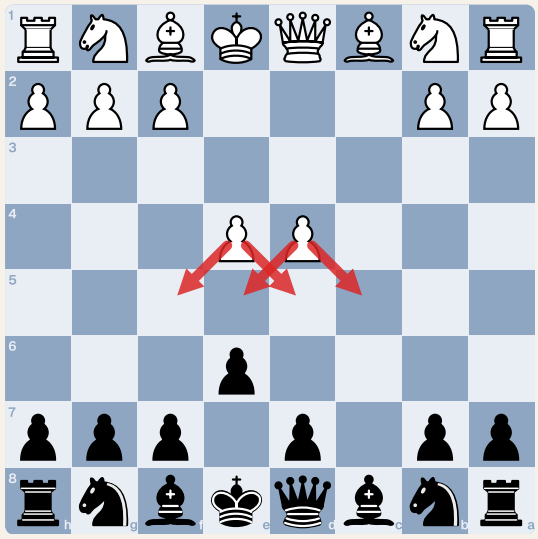


3.d4 White plays d4 with the c3 pawn behind it.

3...cxd4 Black trades...



4.cxd4 ...and White takes back with a pawn: two strong centre pawns.



PIP'S IDEA: WHERE THIS LINE ENDS

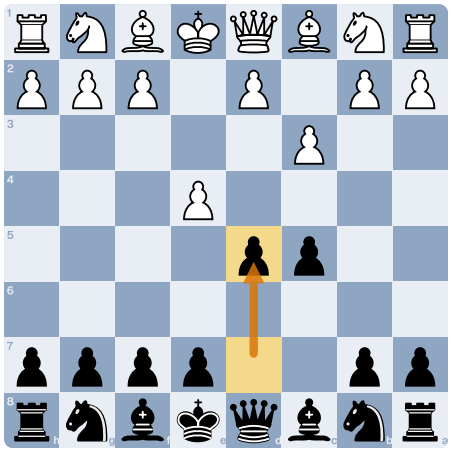
White has the dream centre

White's idea

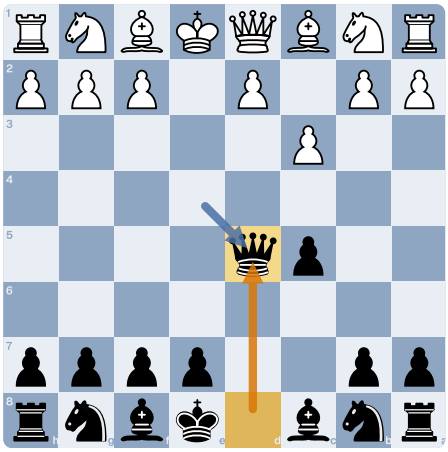
- Two white pawns side by side on d4 and e4 control the middle of the board.
- White's pieces come out easily behind them: Nc3, Nf3 and Bd3.
- Lesson: against 2.c3, play 2...d5! instead of 2...e6.

The answer: 2...d5!

Start from: 1.e4 c5 2.c3



2...d5! Hit the centre now.



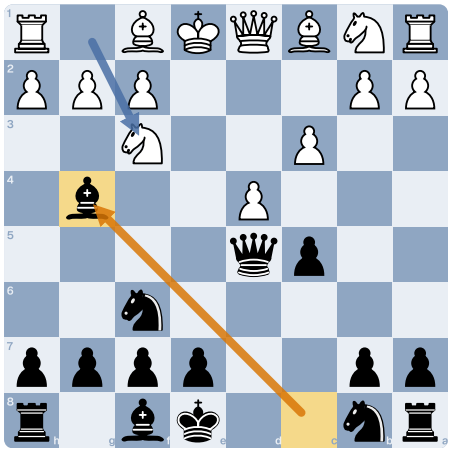
3.exd5 White takes.

3...Qxd5 Safe: c3 has a pawn, so no knight can come to c3 to hit the queen.



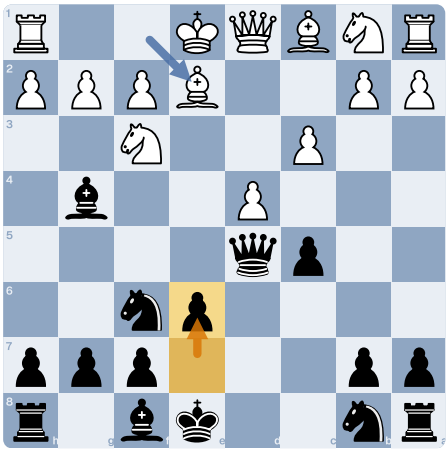
4.d4 White takes the centre.

4...Nf6 Develop.



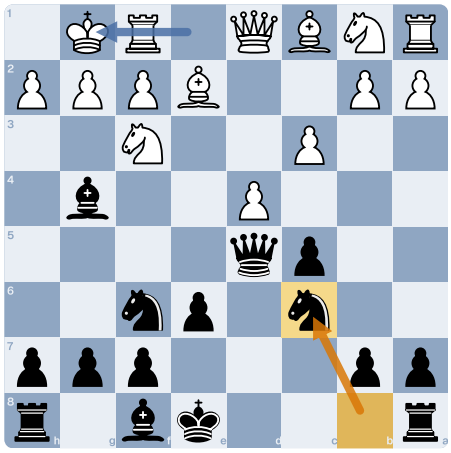
5.Nf3 White develops.

5...Bg4 Bishop out before ...e6 locks it in.



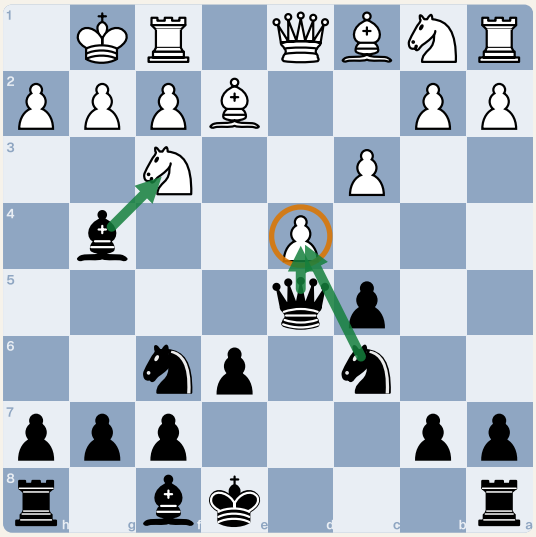
6.Be2 Breaks the pin.

6...e6 Open the f8 bishop.



7.O-O White castles.

7...Nc6 Easy development. Equal.



PIP'S IDEA: WHERE THIS LINE ENDS

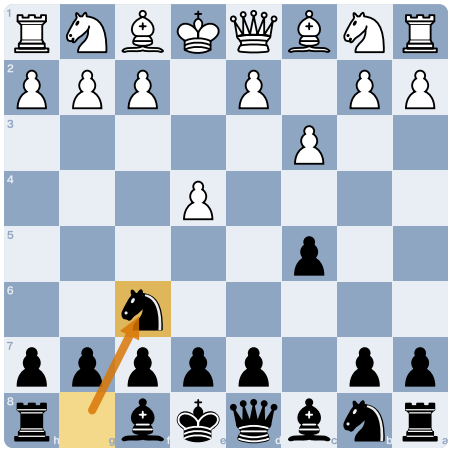
Even game: easy development

Black's plan Key square

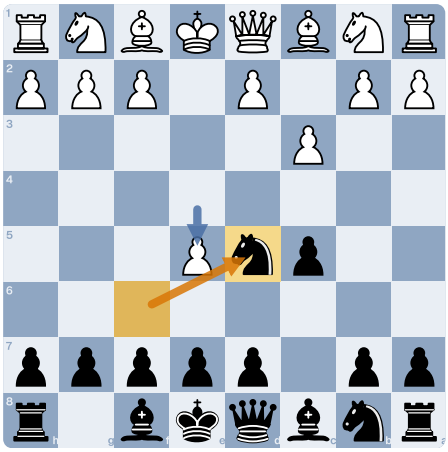
- All of Black's minor pieces are out, and the queen on d5 is safe.
- Black presses on d4: the c5 pawn, the c6 knight and the queen all hit it, and the g4 bishop eyes the f3 knight that guards it.
- Next: ...cxd4, ...Be7 and castle.

Another way: 2...Nf6

Start from: 1.e4 c5 2.c3

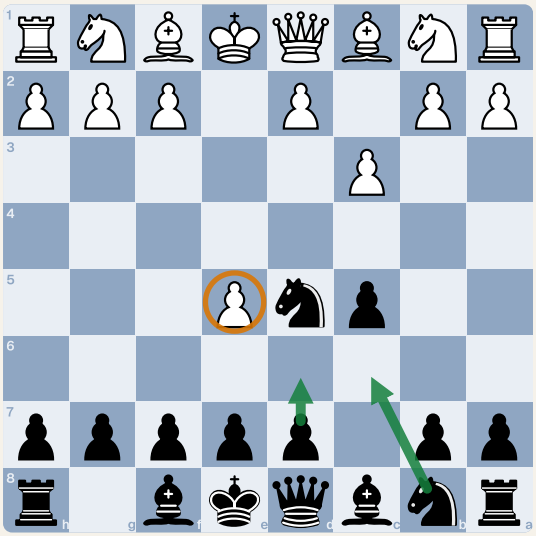


2...Nf6 Hit e4.



3.e5 Kick the knight.

3...Nd5 The knight lands on a great square. A bit trickier.



PIP'S IDEA: WHERE THIS LINE ENDS

Even game

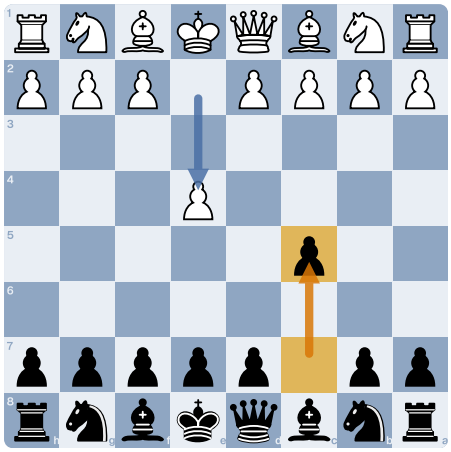
Black's plan Key square

- The knight on d5 is a great central piece, and no pawn can kick it right away.
- The e5 pawn is a target: ...d6 and ...Nc6 will attack it.
- Next: ...Nc6 and ...d6, then develop the bishops.

The video's two games

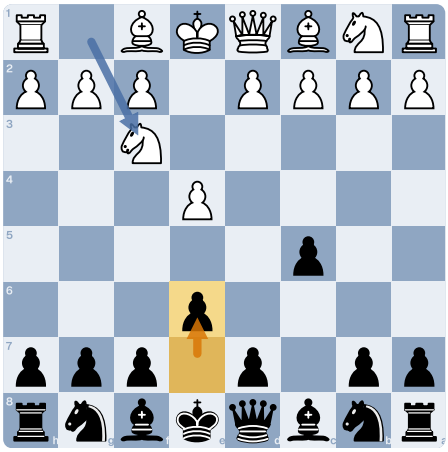
Two real online games, every move. Game 1 began 2.Bc4 e6 3.Nf3, the same position as 2.Nf3 e6 3.Bc4.

Game 1: trap the bishop



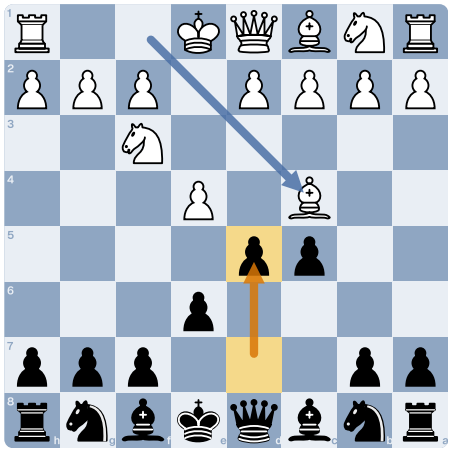
1.e4 White takes the centre.

1...c5 The Sicilian: the c-pawn guards d4 from the side, so White can't have two centre pawns.



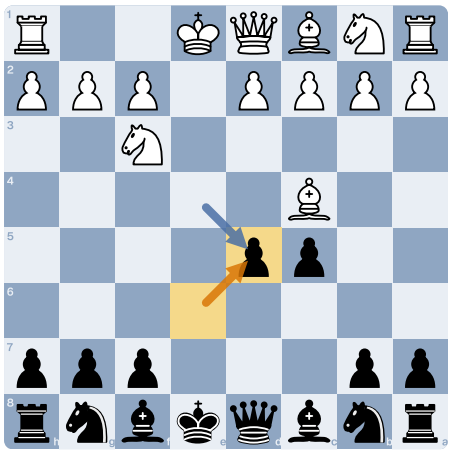
2.Nf3 Develop and get ready for d4.

2...e6 Our setup. The e6 pawn guards d5 and opens a road for the f8 bishop.



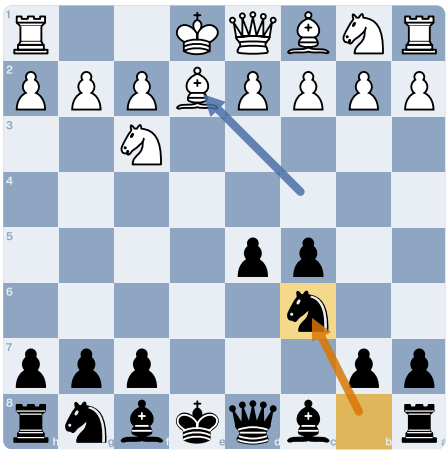
3.Bc4?! Copies the Italian, but the bishop runs into the e6 pawn.

3...d5! Hit the bishop and the centre at once.



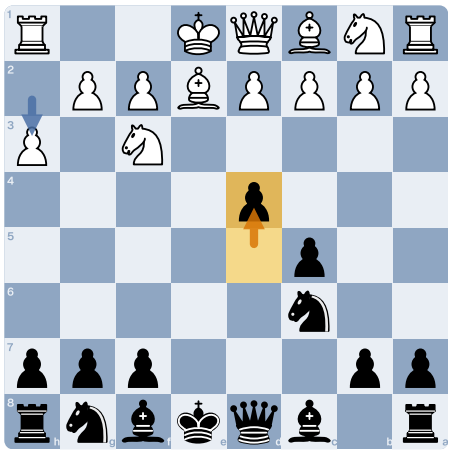
4.exd5 White takes, so the bishop doesn't have to move.

4...exd5 Black now has the only centre pawn, and the c8 bishop is free.



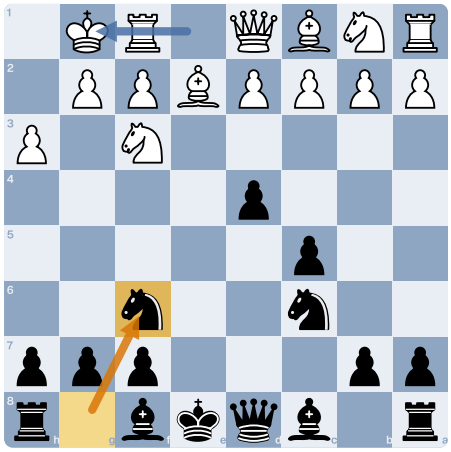
5.Be2 The bishop backs off from c4 instead of checking on b5.

5...Nc6 Develop, and keep an eye on d4.



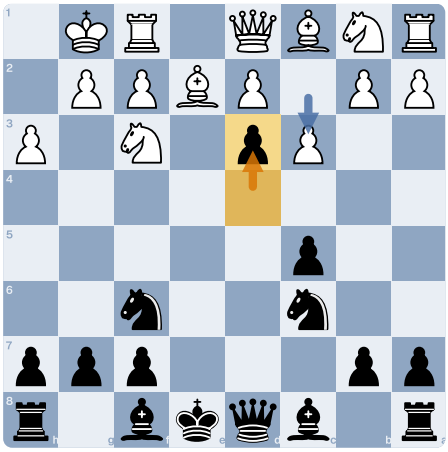
6.h3?! Too slow: it only stops ...Bg4. White should hurry to play d4.

6...d4! Black grabs space and makes sure White never gets d4 in.



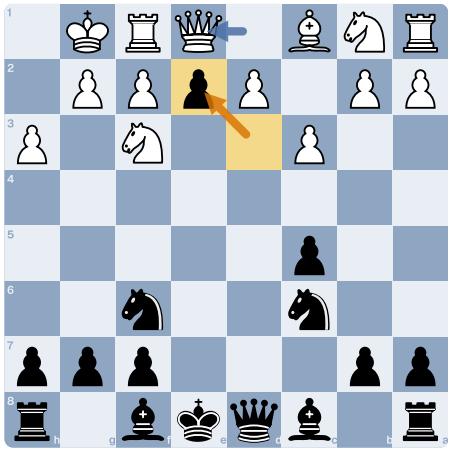
7.O-O White castles.

7...Nf6 Develop and get ready to castle.



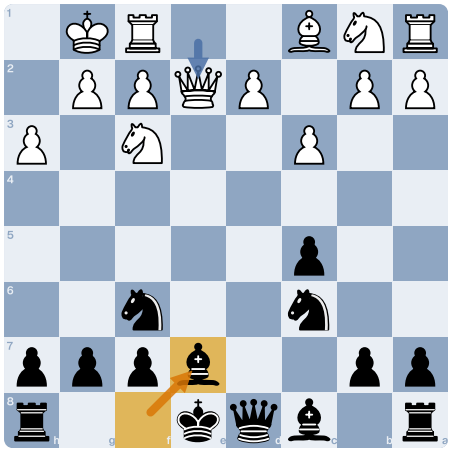
8.c3? Wants to break up Black's d4 pawn, but...

8...d3! ...the pawn jumps past, and the e2 bishop has no safe square: d3 is taken and the other squares are blocked.



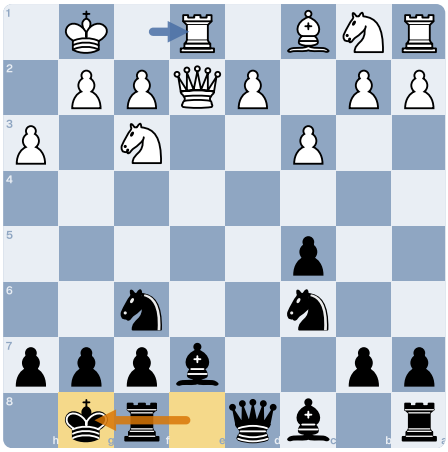
9.Qe1 The bishop is lost anyway, so the queen gets ready to take back on e2.

9...dxe2 Black wins the bishop.



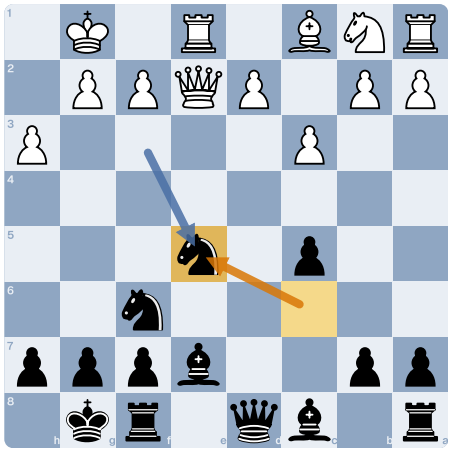
10.Qxe2+ The open e-file gives a check.

10...Be7 Block it. Black is a whole piece up.



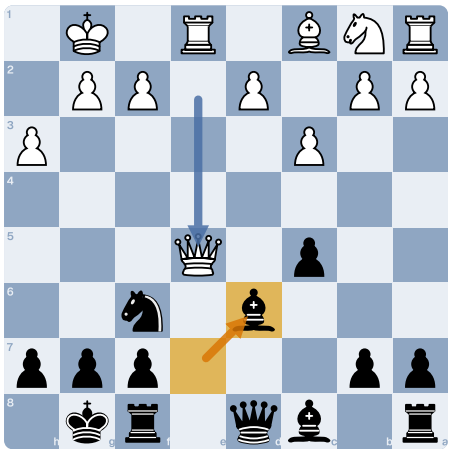
11.Re1 Rook to the open e-file, lining up on the e7 bishop.

11...O-O Castle. The e7 bishop is still guarded by the queen and the c6 knight.



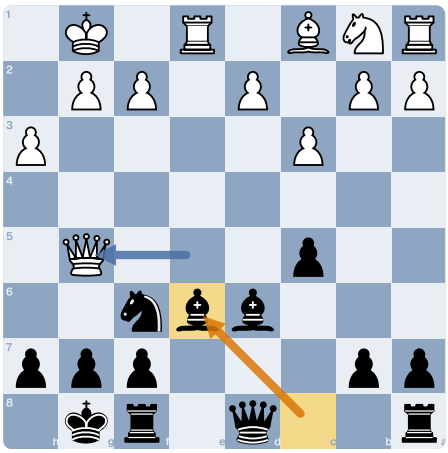
12.Ne5 The knight jumps forward and offers a trade.

12...Nxe5 Take it. When you are a piece up, every trade brings you closer to a win.



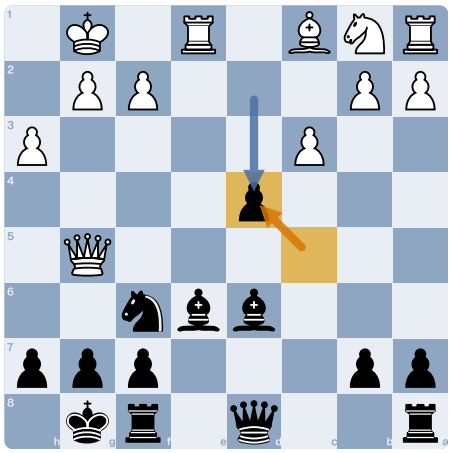
13.Qxe5 The queen takes back and attacks the e7 bishop and the c5 pawn.

13...Bd6 Hit the queen and step off the e-file.



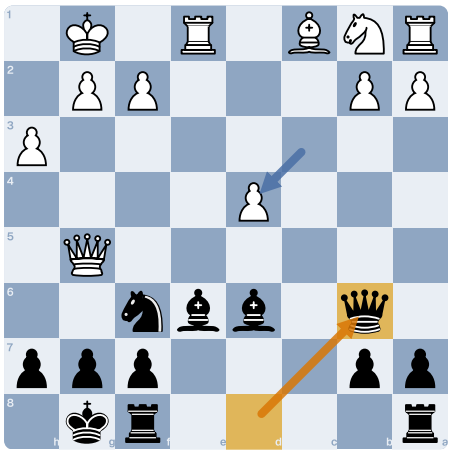
14.Qg5 The queen moves close to Black's king and eyes g7.

14...Be6 Last minor piece out. Now everything is developed.



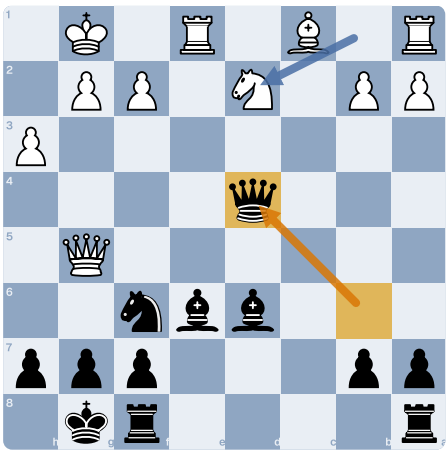
15.d4 White finally plays d4 to open lines.

15...cxd4 Take it.



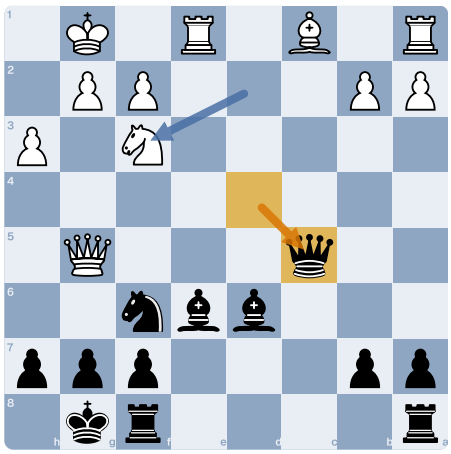
16.cxd4 White takes back, but the d4 pawn has no other guard now.

16...Qb6 The queen hits d4 and b2 at the same time.



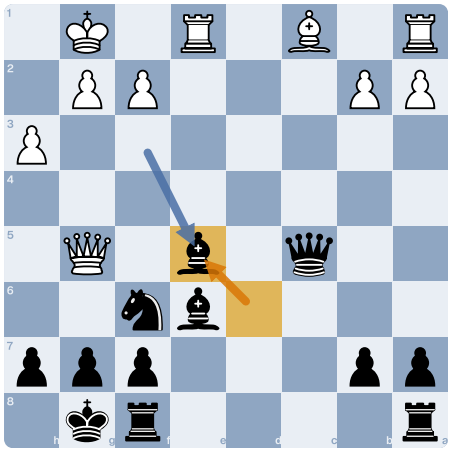
17.Nd2 White develops the knight, but forgets d4.

17...Qxd4 d4 had no guard: take it.



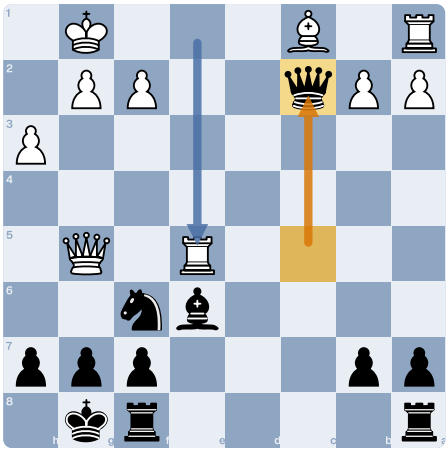
18.Nf3 The knight attacks the queen.

18...Qc5 Step back and offer to trade queens. When you are ahead, trades help.



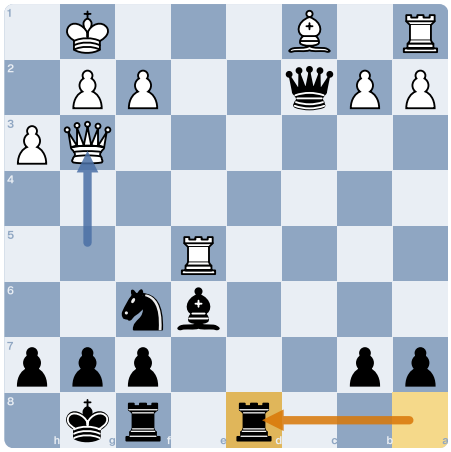
19.Ne5 The knight jumps to the centre again.

19...Bxe5 Trade it off.



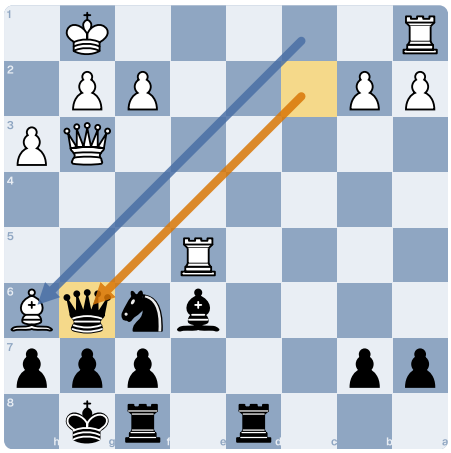
20.Rxe5 The rook takes back and attacks the queen on c5.

20...Qc2 Out of the way, and the queen can still swing back to g6 to guard the king.



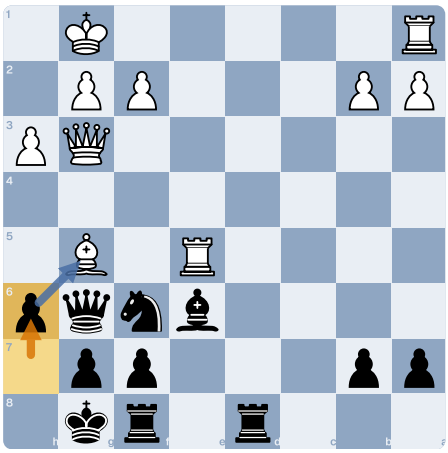
21.Qg3 The queen moves to the g-file, aiming at g7.

21...Rad8 Bring a rook into the game.



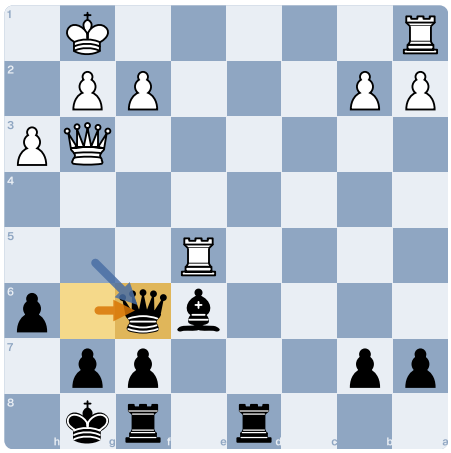
22.Bh6 The g7 pawn can't take: it is pinned to the king. Threat: Qxg7 mate.

22...Qg6! Guard g7, offer a queen trade and hit the h6 bishop.



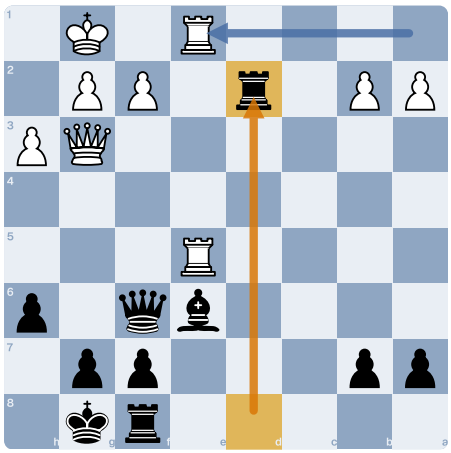
23.Bg5 The bishop steps back and pins the f6 knight to the d8 rook.

23...h6 Kick the bishop.



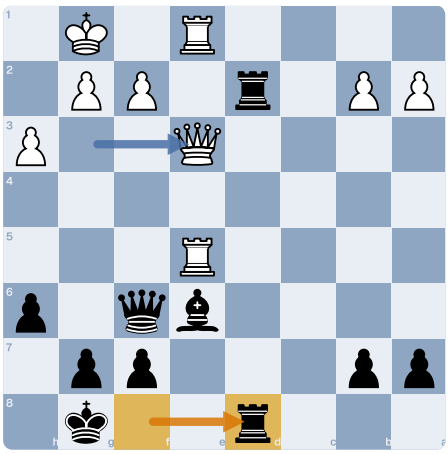
24.Bxf6 White trades the bishop for the knight.

24...Qxf6 The queen takes back.



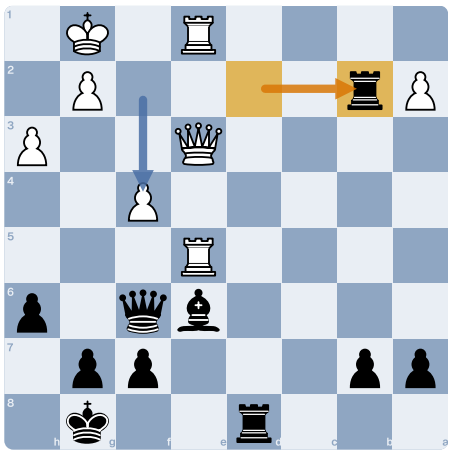
25.Rae1 White puts both rooks on the e-file.

25...Rd2 A rook on the 2nd rank eats pawns.



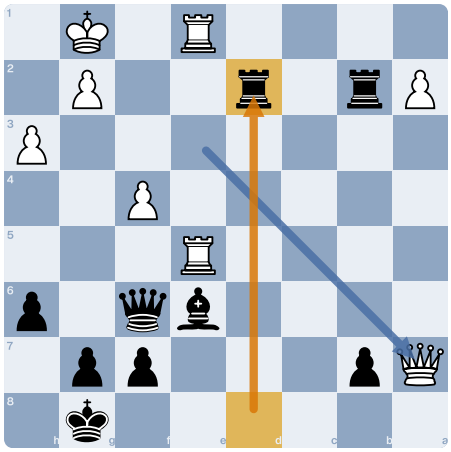
26.Qe3 The queen attacks the d2 rook and the h6 pawn.

26...Rfd8 Guard the rook. If White takes on h6, Black takes on b2.



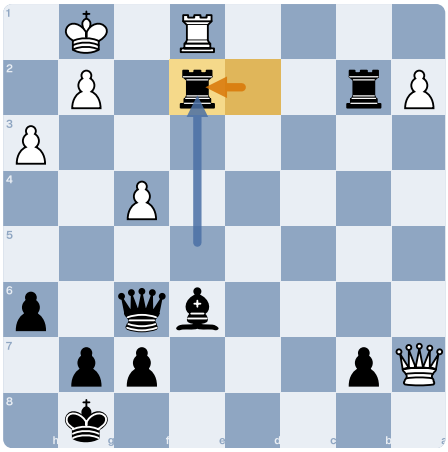
27.f4 White wants f5 to chase the e6 bishop.

27...Rxb2 Free pawn, and the second rank belongs to Black.



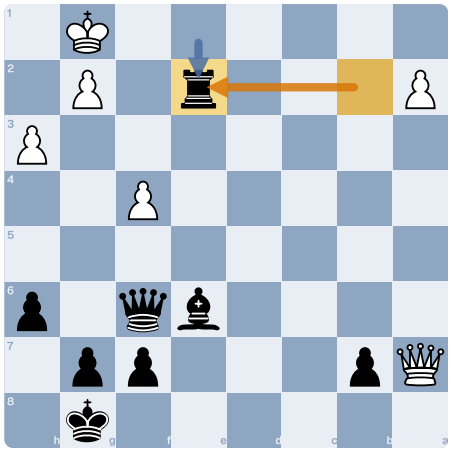
28.Qxa7 White grabs a pawn too.

28...Rdd2 Two rooks on the 2nd rank. Check that your own king is safe first: it can go to h7.



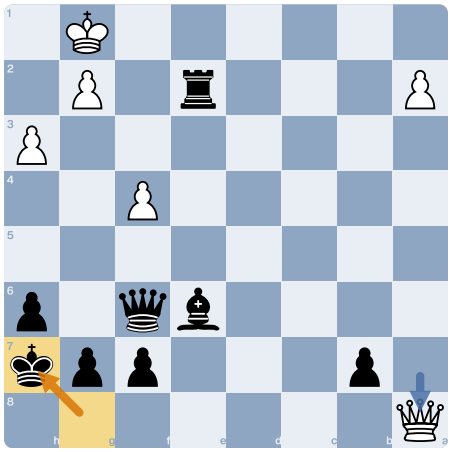
29.R5e2 White blocks with a rook to stop the two black rooks.

29...Rxe2 Take it.



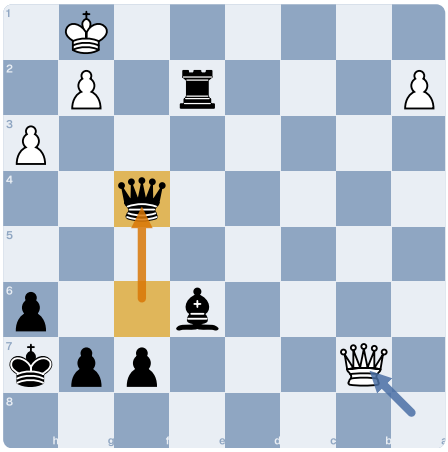
30.Rxe2 White takes back.

30...Rxe2 Take again: the e2 rook was attacked twice and guarded once. Black is a rook and a piece up.



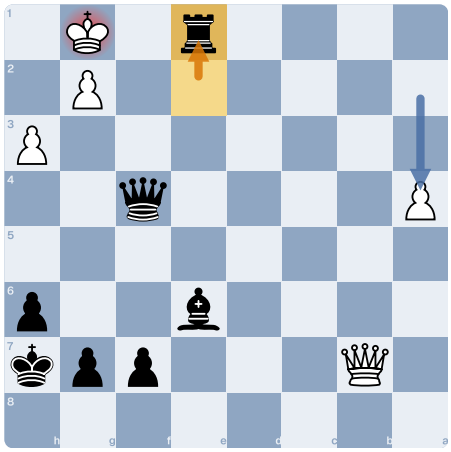
31.Qa8+ A check, the only active move White has.

31...Kh7 The king steps to h7. No more checks.



32.Qxb7 White grabs another pawn.

32...Qxf4 Take the f4 pawn. Now the queen also covers h2.



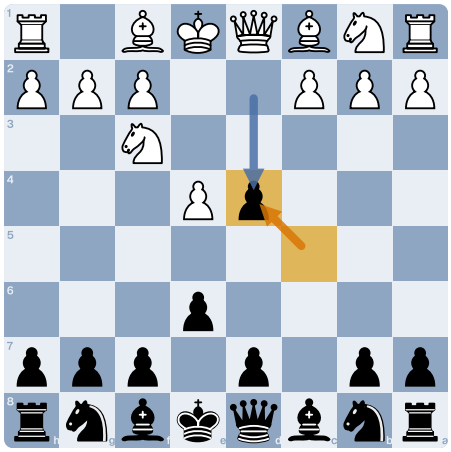
33.a4 White pushes a pawn and misses the threat.

33...Re1# The rook reaches the back rank, and the queen covers h2. Checkmate!

Checkmate! The game ends on the board above.

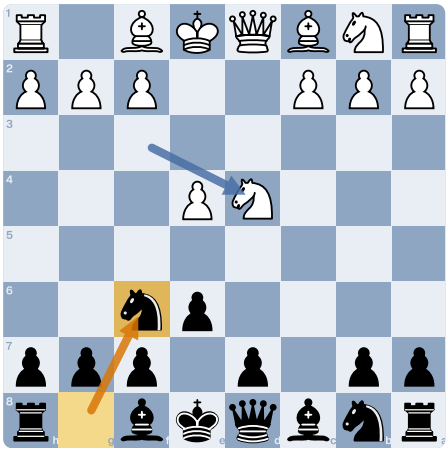
Game 2: the hidden check

Start from: 1.e4 c5 2.Nf3 e6



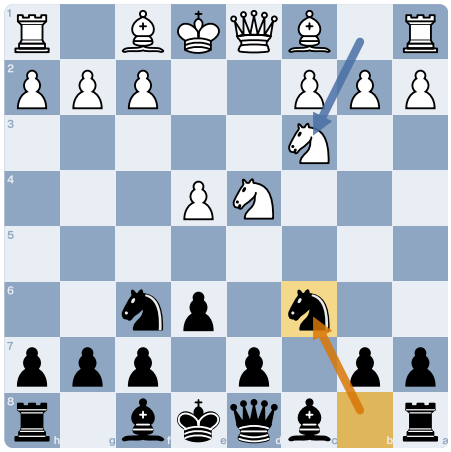
3.d4 The Open Sicilian: White opens the centre.

3...cxd4! Trade a side pawn for a centre pawn.



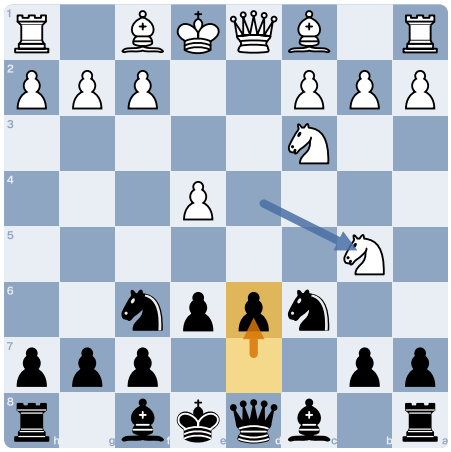
4.Nxd4 The knight takes back and sits in the centre.

4...Nf6 Develop and hit e4.



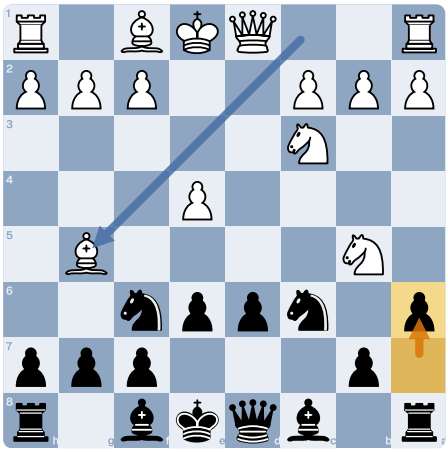
5.Nc3 Guards e4 with a piece. Now ... Qa5 isn't a check any more.

5...Nc6 Develop. (5...d6 is fine too.)



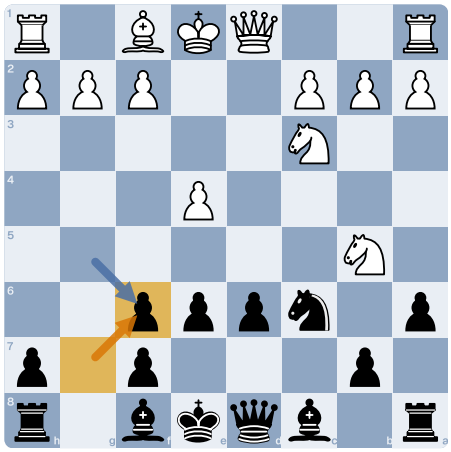
6.Ndb5 The knight wants to jump to d6.

6...d6! Close the d6 square. (6...Be7? 7.Nd6+ is bad for Black.)



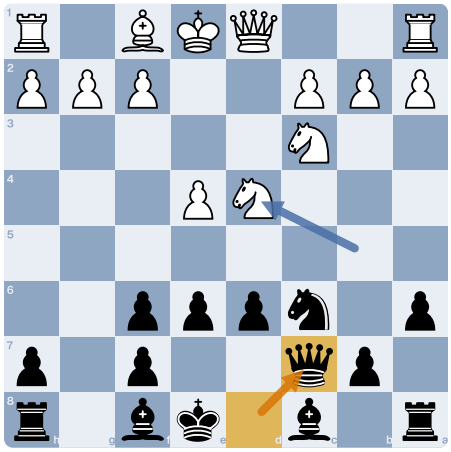
7.Bg5 Pins the f6 knight. (7.Bf4 would force ...e5.)

7...a6 Ask the b5 knight where it is going.



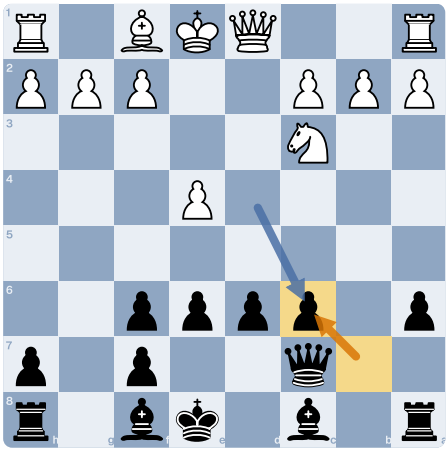
8.Bxf6 Before the knight runs, White gives up the bishop to spoil Black's pawns.

8...gxf6! Pawn takes. 8...Qxf6? 9.Nc7+ forks the king and the a8 rook.



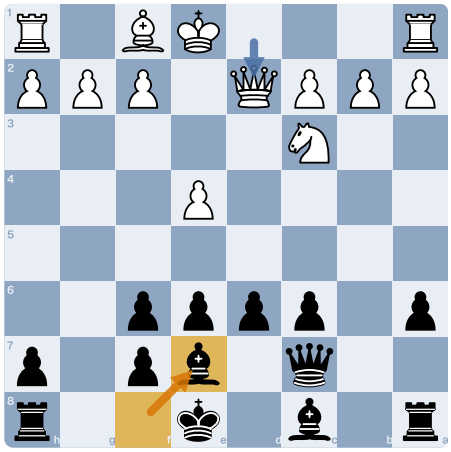
9.Nd4 The knight goes back to the centre.

9...Qc7 Safe from the knights, and it guards c6.



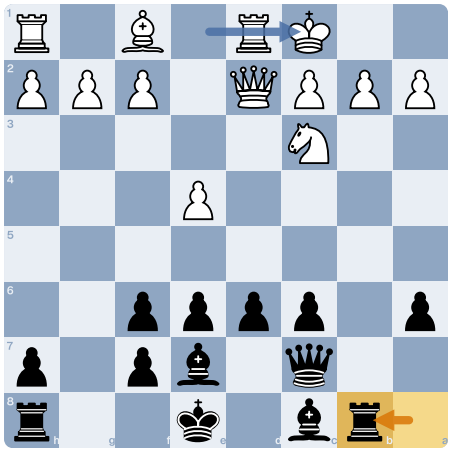
10.Nxc6 White trades knights.

10...bxc6 Take towards the centre.



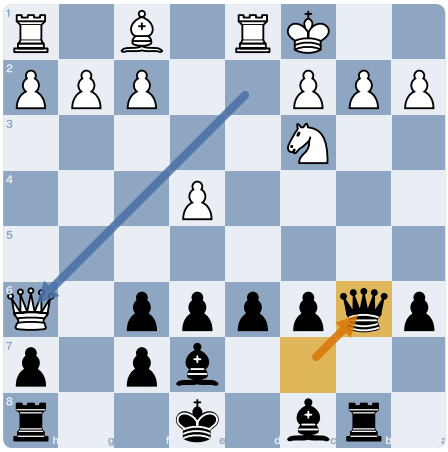
11.Qd2 Queen out, ready to castle long.

11...Be7 Develop and get ready to castle.



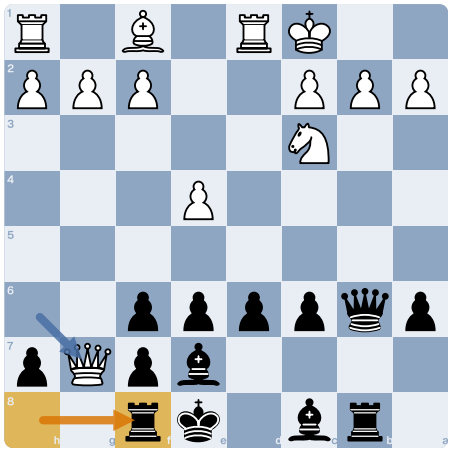
12.O-O-O White castles on the queenside.

12...Rb8 The rook goes to the open b-file, straight at White's king.



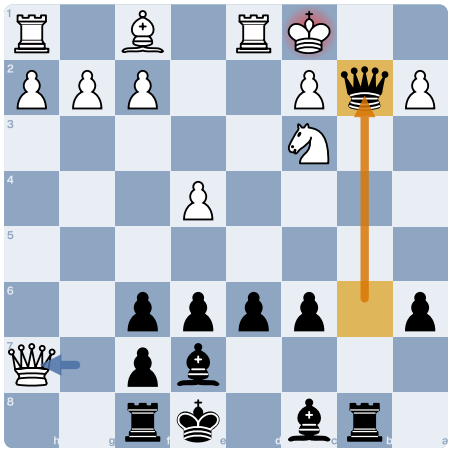
13.Qh6 The queen stops Black castling short (it watches f8) and eyes the h7 pawn.

13...Qb6 Queen and rook line up on the b-file.



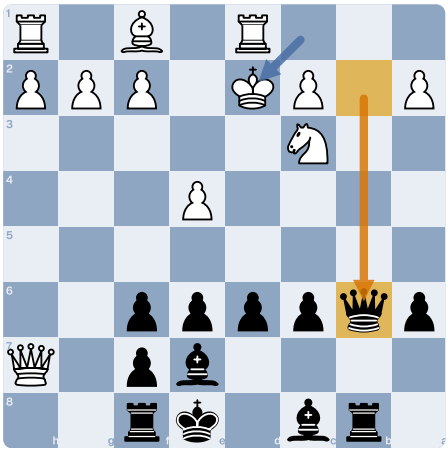
14.Qg7 Hits the h8 rook.

14...Rf8 Just move the rook. When they attack, defend first.



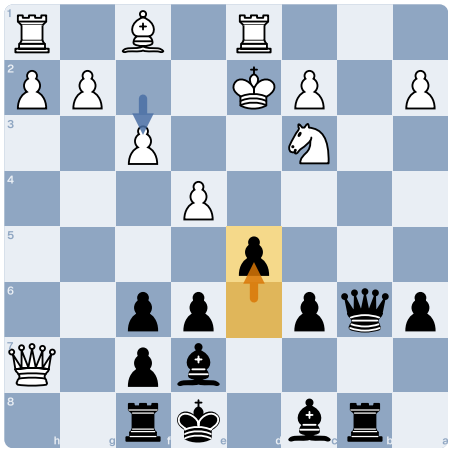
15.Qxh7 White grabs a pawn, but the b-file is open.

15...Qxb2+ Black's attack lands first.



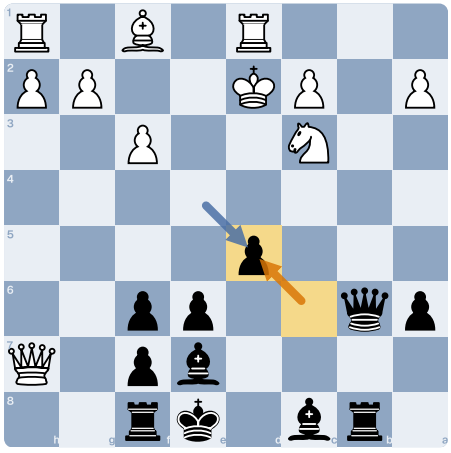
16.Kd2 The king's only square.

16...Qb6 Back to b6 before a rook on b1 can chase her.



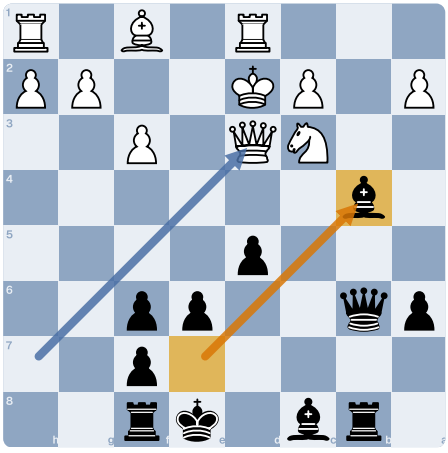
17.f3 White guards e4.

17...d5! Take the centre. Black has the only two centre pawns.



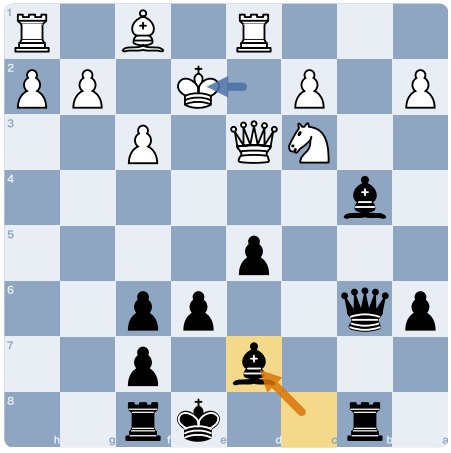
18.exd5 White takes.

18...cxd5 Keep the pawns together.



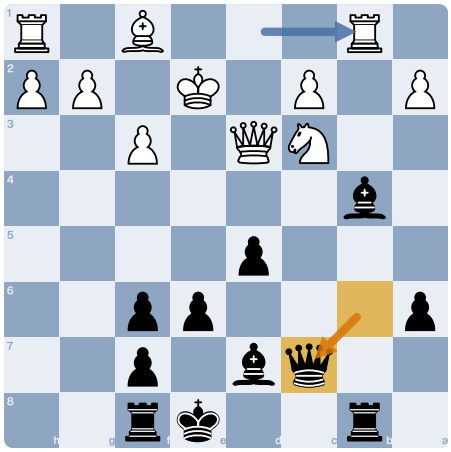
19.Qd3 The queen comes back to defend.

19...Bb4 Pin the c3 knight to the king on d2.



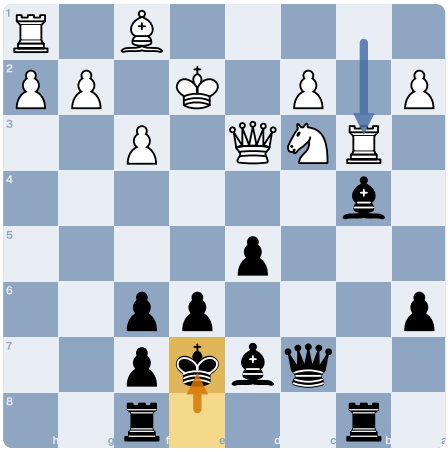
20.Ke2 The king steps off the pin.

20...Bd7 Develop the last bishop.



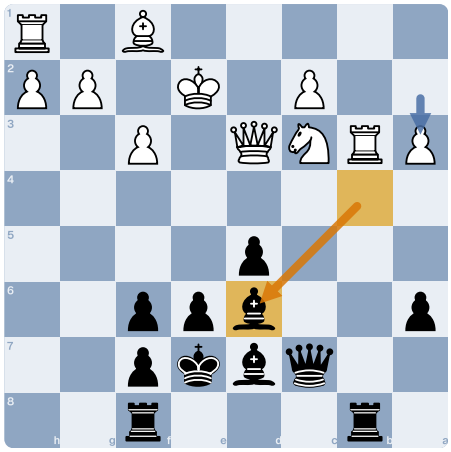
21.Rb1 The rook lines up on the b4 bishop, with Black's queen behind it.

21...Qc7 Step off the b-file so the bishop isn't pinned any more.



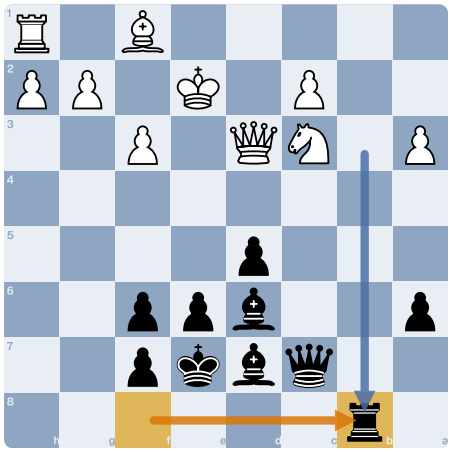
22.Rb3 The rook steps up and guards the c3 knight.

22...Ke7 The king is safe in the middle behind the d5 and e6 pawns.



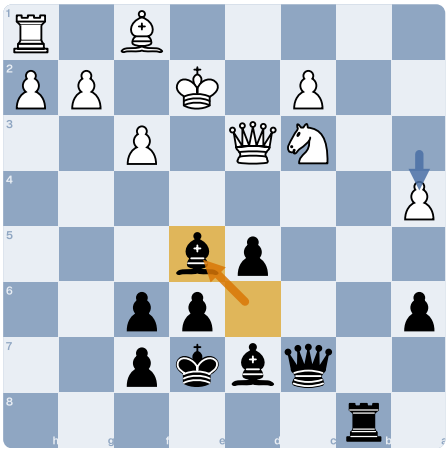
23.a3 The pawn hits the b4 bishop.

23...Bd6 Bishop back. If the rooks trade, the other rook takes back.



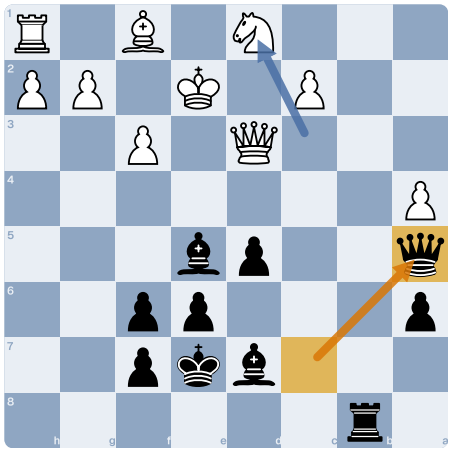
24.Rxb8 White trades rooks.

24...Rxb8 Take back. Black's rook owns the b-file.



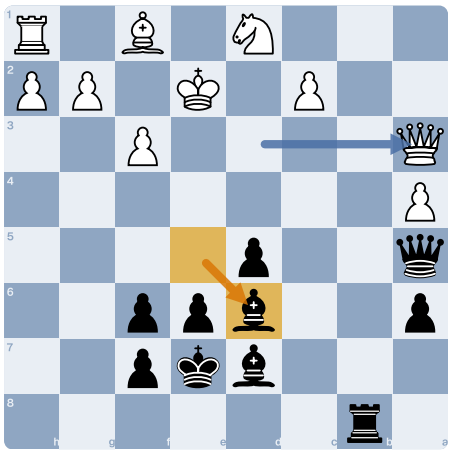
25.a4 The d6 bishop was hitting a3, so the pawn moves on.

25...Be5 Hit the c3 knight, the only guard of a4.



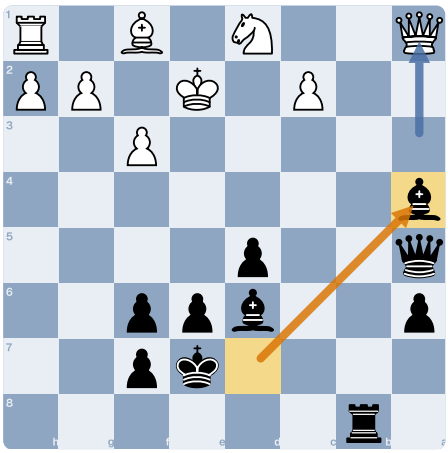
26.Nd1 The knight runs away, so now nothing guards a4.

26...Qa5 Attack a4 again.



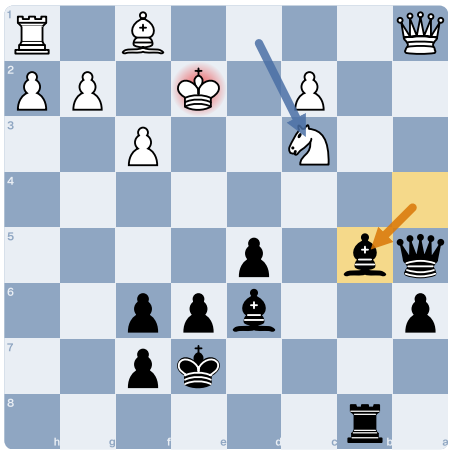
27.Qa3+ Check, and the queen guards a4.

27...Bd6 Block the check, and now the bishop attacks the queen.



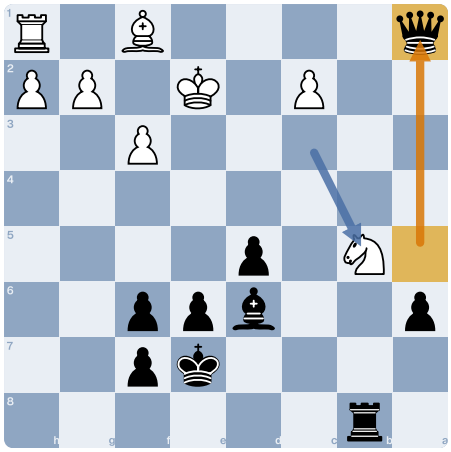
28.Qa1 The queen steps back to a1.

28...Bxa4! Grab the pawn. Now the bishop stands between the two queens.



29.Nc3 The knight attacks the a4 bishop.

29...Bb5+! Check, and the queen behind sees a1.

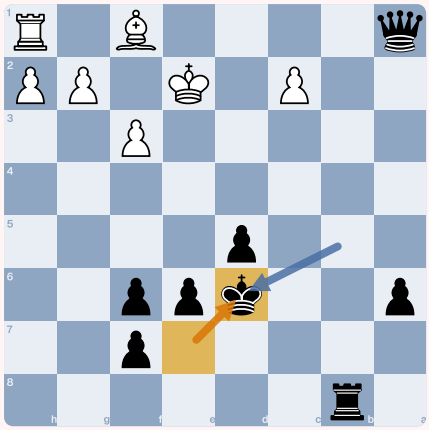


30.Nxb5 White takes the bishop, but…

30...Qxa1 …Black wins the queen. White gave up.

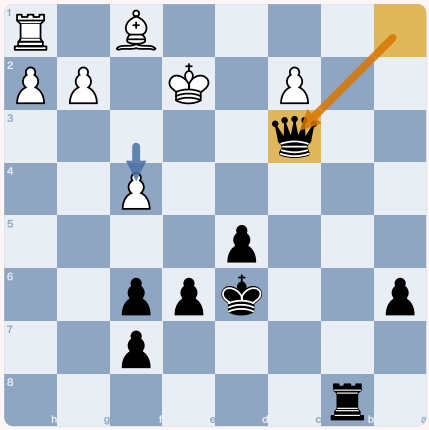
How it would finish

White gave up here. With best play the computer mates in 9 moves:



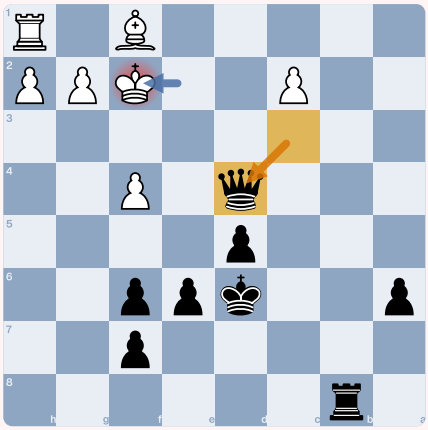
31.Nxd6 White's knight takes the bishop on d6.

31...Kxd6 Black's king takes the knight on d6.



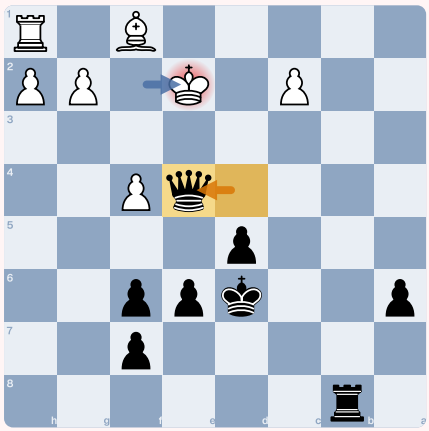
32.f4 White's pawn goes to f4.

32...Qc3 Black's queen goes to c3.



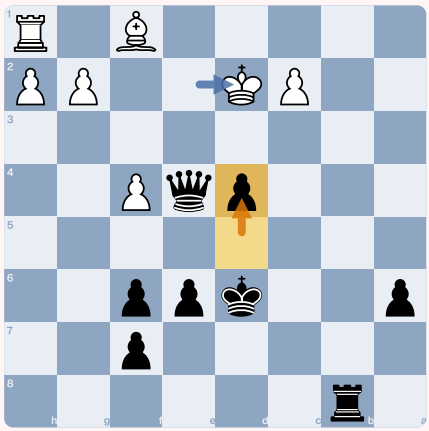
33.Kf2 White's king goes to f2.

33...Qd4+ Black's queen goes to d4. Check!



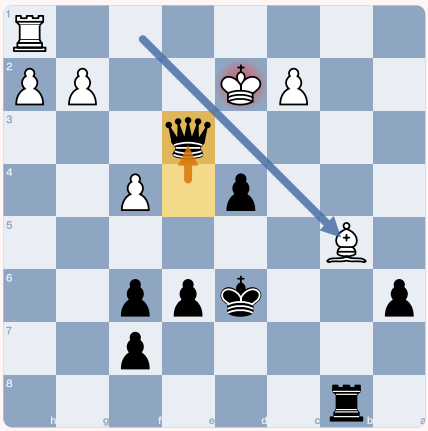
34.Ke2 White's king goes to e2.

34...Qe4+ Black's queen goes to e4. Check!



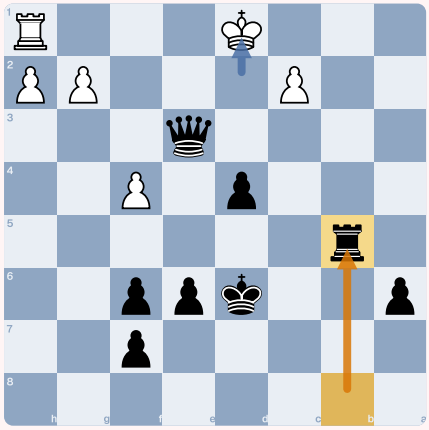
35.Kd2 White's king goes to d2.

35...d4 Black's pawn goes to d4.



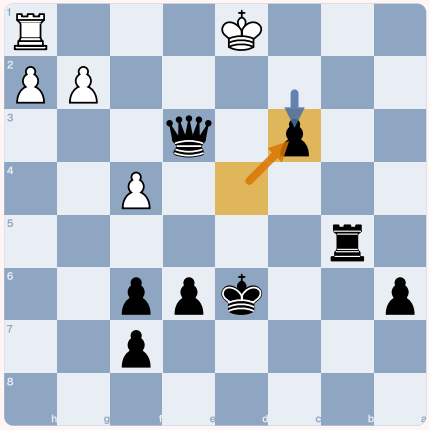
36.Bb5 White's bishop goes to b5.

36...Qe3+ Black's queen goes to e3. Check!



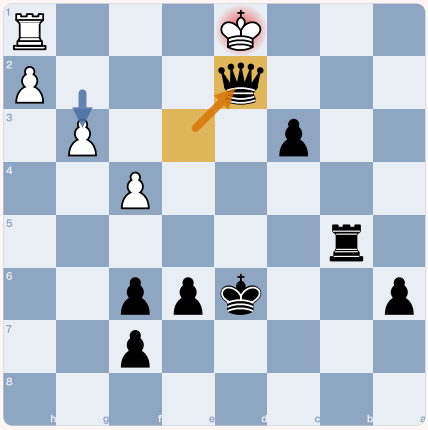
37.Kd1 White's king goes to d1.

37...Rxb5 Black's rook takes the bishop on b5.



38.c3 White's pawn goes to c3.

38...dxc3 Black's pawn takes the pawn on c3.



39.g3 White's pawn goes to g3.

39...Qd2# Black's queen goes to d2. Checkmate! Black wins.